

Three Minutes a Star

written by

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FADE IN:

INT. SMALL BAR - NIGHT

The strings of a RED GUITAR are strummed by a guitar pick, playing a cover of "TAKE IT OR LEAVE IT" by THE STROKES. It's held tightly by a visible hand. There's bracelets on the wrist that look handmade. We zoom out from this hand to see KOTOMI (20s, dyed red hair, casual fashion) performing on a small PLATFORM.

She's singing into a microphone, her voice booming through the crowd. The crowd seems to be a small group, most of them holding various alcoholic beverages in their hands. Some of them are near the bar counter, while others are closer to Kotomi.

Two drunk people cling their drinks together excitedly, some of the liquid splashing onto Kotomi's shirt sleeve. She ignores it and continues to perform.

The front door opens, the bell ringing as a BUFF MAN walks in with an angry expression on his face. Some turn to look at him, while some are still watching the performance.

The buff man yells at the BARTENDER, running up to the counter.

BUFF MAN

You took my fuckin' money, asshole!

Some rush over to hold the buff man back. Kotomi pauses the music for a moment and leans down and raises the volume dial of the amplifier.

In the silence, time seems to stop, everyone staring at each other.

And then, Kotomi continues to the instrumental bridge of the song. The sound is much louder, and drowns out the continued yelling of the buff man.

A drunk man walks up to the buff man and winds up a punch. It hits him square in the face.

The buff man screams and punches him back, the force knocking him right the floor.

Kotomi keeps playing, continuing the instrumental part of the song past where it usually ends. Her hands are moving quickly, sweat pooling on her forehead.

The bartender reaches for his phone, calling someone.

Another drunk person goes to try and grab the buff man. He turns around and headbutts them to the ground.

One man grabs their beer bottle and throws it at the buff man, shattering on his head.

Blood trickles to the ground, drip after drip, and...

A fight breaks out in the bar.

Some people are throwing glasses, and some are throwing punches.

Despite all the screaming and yelling, none of it is audible because of the guitar still shredding riffs.

The fight gets closer to the platform, the buff man piling body after body as more try to gang up on him.

Two people at once run at him and knock him down to the floor. His head lands right next to where the platform is.

Kotomi's shoe is an inch away from his forehead as he looks up at it. He reaches to grab it, but she steps just far back enough to avoid his grasp.

A glass is thrown at the man, shattering right on his bicep. Shards of glass fly through the air, one just barely grazing Kotomi's cheek. A tiny scratch forms.

But Kotomi doesn't stop playing. In fact, she closes her eyes.

Red and blue lights start to glow from the windows as police cars pull up outside the bar.

Sweat drips down Kotomi's face, and she takes a deep breath.

She smiles. And that smile does not waver.

And with the final riff, the song ends.

CUT TO:

INT. SMALL BAR - LATER

Police are gathered inside the bar, chatter filling the room as they're talking to one of the customers that got punched in the face. We don't hear exactly what they're saying.

The police leave the scene, and we see the remains of the damage. The place itself seemed mostly intact besides the glass on the floor and some bloodstains.

A worker is brushing glass from the floor, a tired look on his face.

We see the bartender, who passes a beer over to Kotomi. She is sitting down by the counter, and grabs the bottle with a nod.

BARTENDER

If it makes ya feel better, it was worse three nights ago. Singer got a giant gash right in the forehead. Passed out on the spot.

The bartender points to her forehead, making a slicing gesture across it.

KOTOMI

Yeah, counting my blessings.

Kotomi takes a sip of her beer, shaking her head as she swallows. She rests her elbow against the counter, leaning her head into her palm, when...

The bell rings again, the door swinging open. Three young people walk inside the bar.

The first one is JOSEPHINE (20s, punk, studded jacket), who has a guitar case strapped to her back. She laughs before taking the spot next to Kotomi.

JOSEPHINE

Dude. Don't tell me you did this.

KOTOMI

Yeah, had the worst day of my life and needed to let the stress out.

Josephine continues to cackle, slamming her hand on the counter. The bartender gives her a dirty look, before slowly walking up to her. And without even waiting for the bartender to ask...

JOSEPHINE

You know my usual, right?

The bartender nods, and goes to start mixing something. Meanwhile, the two other people who walked in were talking off to the side, and one of them turns to join Kotomi and Josephine.

This person is ZACHARY (20s, eyepatch, tall), who has a clear limp as he stumbles over to sit on Kotomi's other side. A faint smile curls on his lips, and he turns towards Josephine.

ZACHARY

We agreed not to hound her 'bout it.

Josephine scoffs, and slams her palm against the counter again. Kotomi grabs onto her drink and picks it up off the counter.

JOSEPHINE

Oh, shut up Zach, I haven't even said a word! Not even a letter! Right, 'Tomi? Tell him, tell him!

Kotomi rolls her eyes.

KOTOMI

She told me she'd choke me to death if I scared off the crowd again.

ZACHARY

Josie...

JOSEPHINE

Oh, come on, you're seriously gonna believe that shit?

The bartender comes back with a MIDORI SOUR, placing it in front of Josephine. She quickly grabs it and raises it, holding it out towards Kotomi.

Kotomi moves to raise her bottle, but is interrupted by shuffling behind her. She slowly turns her head to see the third person, FELIX (20s, blonde hair, designer clothing), place his hands on her shoulders.

Josephine still thrusts her drink in Kotomi's direction, but without a glass to hit, the frantic movement spills a small amount onto the table. The bartender grumbles before walking to grab a napkin.

FELIX

Good to see you again, Kotomi.

KOTOMI

Mhm. Wanna join them?

FELIX

In what?

KOTOMI

Accusing me.

FELIX

Oh sweetheart, I'd never do that.

Felix takes a spot next to Zachary, wrapping his arm around his shoulder. He snaps his fingers into a pointing gesture as he raises it to the bartender.

The bartender nods his head, dropping the napkin in front of the group before going to mix another drink.

JOSEPHINE

Again, I didn't say anything!

Kotomi grabs the napkin and wipes the counter in front of them, washing the drink away. She crumples the napkin in her hand and tosses in the air.

KOTOMI

You thought I did it.

She catches the napkin effortlessly, placing it down on the counter.

ZACHARY

Josie, really? Like she'd ruin a gig.

KOTOMI

If nobody paid me, I would.

ZACHARY

You get any tip at least?

KOTOMI

More than usual, surprisingly.
Maybe they felt bad.

FELIX

Care to share with the rest of us then?

Josephine glances at him sharply, reaching out to try and grab his hand. She's just out of reach.

JOSEPHINE

Yeah, 'cause daddy's money isn't enough for you?

FELIX

Hey, I said all of us, not just me!
And we were supposed to play.

ZACHARY

We can always play tomorrow.

Felix nods, sighing as he watches the bartender return with a WHISKEY SOUR. He gently picks it up, holding it near Zachary's mouth. He sips it carefully.

Kotomi chugs down the rest of her beer before standing from her seat.

JOSEPHINE

Hey, leaving so soon? We came here to see ya!

KOTOMI

It's past midnight and I'm tired as fuck. We can hang another time, promise.

JOSEPHINE

Yeah, we will.

Josephine imitates the gesture of tying a noose, hands moving around her neck before she pulls her hand up in a quick motion, dropping her head. She then bursts out into laughter.

FELIX

Hey, hey, if you're going to leave anyways, indulge me first.

Kotomi turned her head to face him, barely an expression on her face.

KOTOMI

With...?

FELIX

The game.

KOTOMI

But I didn't prepare-

ZACHARY

I wouldn't mind.

FELIX

See? He doesn't mind.

JOSEPHINE

Oh, oh! If we're playing, I call first dibs!

KOTOMI

If I'm terrible, I'm blaming Felix.

Felix gasped sarcastically while Kotomi walked over to the platform where she performed previous.

Josephine hopped over, a wide smile on her face. When Zachary and Felix stood up, they stayed huddled close before hovering a few feet away from the platform.

Josephine took the guitar case off her back, unzipping it quickly to reveal a YELLOW BASS GUITAR before rushing onto the platform. After connecting it to the amplifier and setting everything up, she stomped her foot as loud as she could.

JOSEPHINE

Are you motherfuckers ready?

And then, she started to play a heavy tune, hitting the distortion pedal as the abrasive news had Zachary covering his ears.

Moments later, she stopped. The three of them clapped awkwardly.

KOTOMI

That was awesome.

JOSEPHINE

I know, right? Told ya Hendrix blessed me.

Josephine unplugged her guitar before hopping off the platform, gesturing to Felix. He nodded and took her spot, holding the mic stand firmly before he began to sing.

His singing wasn't terrible, although it wasn't great either. When he finished, he bowed.

Kotomi and Zachary clapped.

KOTOMI

Pretty good, but my vote's still on Josie.

ZACHARY

I... change my vote to you.

FELIX

At least someone has sense.

Felix steps down, glaring at Josephine, who only shook her head in return. Kotomi grabbed her guitar leaning against the bar counter, walking up to the platform to plug it in.

With a deep breath in, she began to play and sing. She was performing an original song, one that had all of her audience speechless.

At the very end, her last chord was slightly off-key. The rest of them clap nonetheless.

JOSEPHINE

Almost as good as mine! Vote's on you, cherry!

FELIX

Delightful, really. Take my vote.

ZACHARY

I... I'm still voting for Felix. But that was very good.

KOTOMI

Tell that to my usual crowd. You don't remember the tomato?

ZACHARY

Maybe if you put a little more trust in them.

KOTOMI

They threw an actual tomato at me! Like, who even brings one to a bar?

FELIX

That won't happen every time. They banned that guy, remember? Last time I played-

KOTOMI

You have cushion to fall back on if you fail. We don't all get allowances at 25.

FELIX

Do you not always complain about... this? This life?

KOTOMI

Of course I do! You think I wouldn't rather be on a real stage?

JOSEPHINE

Then just go do it already!

KOTOMI

I'm gonna throw a tomato at you.

As the four of them argue, their voices become blended together, the bar lights dimming. The night was coming to a close.

INT. TINY APARTMENT - DAY

A small, claustrophobic apartment is messy and littered with clothes and various trinkets on the ground. Walls are painted white, though the paint seems worn out and dirty in some areas. There's a few band and artist posters. The only clean area is the shiny red guitar sitting in the corner.

In bed, we see Kotomi sleeping. Her hair is out of sorts, she's drooling onto the pillow, and clinging onto her blanket. Nothing out of the ordinary.

She wakes up with a yawn, blinking her eyes over and over before forcing herself to sit up. She stretches briefly and then hops out of bed.

There's a quick montage of her getting ready in the morning.

First, she tries to tidy up her bed, but gives up after she keeps dropping part of the blanket onto the floor.

Next, she's in her small kitchen which is in the same room as the rest of her apartment. She opens her fridge, which is full of mostly microwavable meals and leftovers. She takes out a container full of leftover ramen and throws it quickly in the microwave.

While it's cooking, she's in front of her black dresser, opening one of the drawers. There are a few shirts inside, and a Taco Bell branded polo shirt. She grabs it reluctantly.

She's now seen changed into the Taco Bell worker uniform, blowing on the steaming hot noodles while she sits at the edge of her bed.

She takes a bite, coughing but forcing it down anyways.

When the container is half full, she sets it down next to her, pulling out her phone. It's an older model Samsung phone, but works fine as she dials a number and calls it.

The phone rings. And it goes to voicemail.

KOTOMI

Hey, uh... I just wanted to tell
you I had the craziest time last
night. Some huge dude came into the
place, started messing everyone up.
Think you would've found it funny.

Her voice shakes as she pauses. She hovers the hang up button, but doesn't.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)

My singing's gotten better. I told you it would. Just took a little while. I won't be going anywhere for the next few months at least, if you wanna come by and hear it. I...

She pauses again. And then shakes her head.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)

Never mind. Call me back if you want. Love you, mom.

She hangs up the phone, and there's a moment of silence while she sits in bed.

When she puts her phone in her pocket, she closes the container of food and stands up. She grabs her keys, her wallet, and walks towards her door.

But before she reaches the door, she grunts, grabbing her stomach as she doubles over.

Her knees give out, and she tumbles to the ground.

She reaches out to find something to grab onto, missing the first few times before she finds the doorknob. She uses it as leverage to rise to her feet.

And just when she tries to open the door again, she winces and falls back to the ground.

She looks up at the ceiling, reaching her arm out towards it and outstretching her fingers. Her arm falls to her side, and she glances back over to her bed.

She can see a glimpse of the red from her guitar before she falls unconscious.

INT. EMERGENCY ROOM - DAY

Kotomi is lying down in a hospital bed, in gown with an IV in her arm. A disgruntled look is on her face briefly, but leaves when a DOCTOR walks in.

DOCTOR

I'm very sorry, Ms. Kurosawa.

Kotomi shuffles in her bed, leaning back against the pillow as she props herself up.

KOTOMI

Just tell me what's going on. Felt like the flu or something.

DOCTOR

Flu doesn't bring you straight to the ER.

KOTOMI

Well, I tried going to work. Boss insisted I get checked up, and there weren't any appointments available with my usual.

DOCTOR

Better you got here earlier than later. Prepare yourself. It'll be difficult.

KOTOMI

Prepared.

The doctor looks at his clipboard for a moment, before tapping it with his pen. And his expression goes somber.

DOCTOR

You have a... condition. A rare one.

KOTOMI

Which is...?

DOCTOR

We don't have a name for it yet. There's a couple indicators, from your specific symptoms to what we found from the blood test.

KOTOMI

I lucked out, didn't I?

DOCTOR

I suppose, if you want to put it that way. But to be honest, I'm going to need you to be a little more serious here.

KOTOMI

Yeah, sorry.

DOCTOR

Those who have the condition don't exactly report very great results.
(MORE)

DOCTOR (CONT'D)

I can prescribe medication to help the symptoms, but there's no knowing right now how effective it'll be.

KOTOMI

Can't afford it. I need to dig in my savings just for this visit.

DOCTOR

I'll get you the minimum, at least. But just so you know, it might be your only chance to hold it off until we find better treatment. There's lots of research being done, but they can only work so fast.

KOTOMI

How screwed am I if I don't take any?

DOCTOR

You'll have a few weeks, maybe a month until it takes you. And it'll be gradual, so even in the next days it might get worse. I highly suggest you try and pay for the medication.

Kotomi's eye twitches. She almost jolts out of her seat, but stays. Her voice grows a little louder, more frantic in nature.

KOTOMI

Are you serious? There's nothing else I can do?

DOCTOR

I'm very sorry. There are programs to help with financial aid, but because this is such a new and unknown condition, it'll be harder to lay off the whole price.

KOTOMI

I... wow. Alright.

DOCTOR

I'll give you time to think about it. But please, your safety is important. You can worry about the money after you've secured your life.

The doctor nods, before walking away quickly behind the curtain. Kotomi is now alone, her face moving to rest in the palms of her hands.

There's a few tears noticeably seeping between her fingers and dripping to her gown.

KOTOMI

Fuck.

INT TINY APARTMENT - NIGHT

Kotomi is sitting down on her bed. She holds a PILL BOTTLE in her hand with her name on it, and instructions that say "NO MORE THAN 1 a day, refill as needed". She turns the bottle, a further warning saying "Side effects include:", but she doesn't turn it further to read them.

In the background, her phone could be heard.

PHONE

Your call has been forwarded to voicemail. This mailbox is full, so the call will end shortly.

Once it ends, the lock screen is visible on her bedside table. The screen shows Kotomi with a neutral look on her face, surrounded by JOSEPHINE, ZACHARY, and FELIX with huge smiles on their faces as they crowd her from all sides.

She stands up, turning her head to the left with her guitar is. A couple quick steps follow, and she reaches down to pick it up gently. The pill bottle clatters to the floor.

She holds the guitar in her hands, her fingers tracing the strings one after another.

Now from the back of her head, it's impossible to see what her expression might be.

The guitar is put into a playing position, and she stays still.

Now that we see her expression, it's devoid of anything that can be discerned, except for her closed eyes.

She suddenly grabs the guitar by the neck, turning it 180 degrees, and in a swift motion...

She nearly slams it into the nearby wall, but stops herself inches before the collision. The guitar is put back where it was.

A thud sounds through the room as she flops defeatedly on her bed, sprawling her limbs out along the sheets and grunting.

KOTOMI

(mocking Josephine)

Then just go do it already! Just go
do it already! Just go do it
already...

Her voice is muffled as she continued to mumble into her pillow, now intelligible.

The sun from her window shines down on her, and she turns around to look at it. A hand shields her eyes, squinting from how bright it is.

Besides her, the pill bottle she dropped is barely within the rays of light. It is illuminated nonetheless.

She reaches down and picks it up again. The plastic reflects the light, and it's almost like a gem in her hands. The guitar on the side is shrouded in darkness.

With a slow twisting motion, she takes the cap off of the bottle. There's only 10 pills inside.

One pill falls into her palm. She looks at it for a while.

She tips the pill bottle slightly, and a few more fall into her palm.

And then a few more.

And more.

She hesitates more before getting up and walking over to her kitchen. The light gets dimmer as she walks away, and she clutches the pills tightly.

She opens the cupboard, a small cloud of dust erupting and hitting her in the face.

Brushing it off, she grabs a cup and fills it up with water from the sink.

She places the cup on the table and looks at it.

The water swishes slightly, before going stagnant.

She continues to stare at it, appearing as if she's contemplating about something.

There's a notification from her phone. It's far away from where she's standing, but she glances over at it anyways.

It was a text message from someone, but she couldn't see who it was. All she could see was that same lock screen again.

She's staring at everyone's smiles. Her own lips almost curl, but they don't.

Her eyes dart back to the glass, and she picks it up.

The hand holding the pills gravitate towards her mouth, but she doesn't quite take them.

Instead, she looks over at the guitar, which is still covered by shadows.

And her eyes narrow.

INT. BASEMENT - DAY

Kotomi is turning the tuning pegs on her guitar carefully, strumming each string after tuning the respective peg. She sighs from the odd sound one of them makes, and keeps turning and strumming until it sounds in tune again.

She's sitting down on a wooden box near a wall with chipped paint and scratches all over it. She's tapping her foot over and over on the floor, constantly moving one of the tiles that isn't quite flush.

On the other side of the room, Zachary sat next to a drum set, using drumsticks to hit them over and over. He was clearly skilled, although he seemed to be making a very monotone and boring beat.

Next to him, Felix watched closely, his face beaming with admiration. His eyes were wide, a big smile that seemed to almost reach his slicked-back hair.

KOTOMI

Did you wanna run it back?

Zachary looked at her worried for a second, but quickly resumed his usual calm expression.

ZACHARY

Yeah, I just need to get this rhythm down.

KOTOMI

It's the same over and over. I think you got it.

ZACHARY

No... it's slightly off. Just a tiny bit.

KOTOMI

Being a perfectionist won't get you anywhere. You think anybody notices that?

ZACHARY

Says you! Do you not remember-

KOTOMI

Shut it.

Josephine walks down the stairs near Kotomi, her steps stomping and sound reverberating through the basement until she reaches the second to last step.

She jumps from the step to the ground, her hands darting into the air.

JOSEPHINE

Miss me?

KOTOMI

Always.

JOSEPHINE

I heard we were talking about when 'Tomi-

KOTOMI

We weren't talking about anything!

JOSEPHINE

When she nearly broke that mic stand because she missed a note?

The entire group went silent, everyone slowly turning their heads to Kotomi.

Luckily, she didn't seem very fazed by the comment.

KOTOMI

I'd do it again. Now come on, let's play already before it gets too late.

FELIX

Why, have somewhere to be?

Kotomi shook her head no.

KOTOMI

If you all wanna be here past midnight, be my guest. Just looking out for you.

JOSEPHINE

Oh! Oh actually, I can't stay that long!

KOTOMI

Got a date?

JOSEPHINE

Date with some sweet, sweet cash coming in, that's what!

KOTOMI

New job, congrats.

ZACHARY

Oh Josie, did the record store finally give you an interview?

JOSEPHINE

Zach. The agent.

ZACHARY

Oh... yeah.

JOSEPHINE

I mean, I don't get the cash today, but I need to work on my interview skills-

KOTOMI

Agent?

JOSEPHINE

Yeah, you don't know?

Kotomi jumps from her seat, gripping her guitar tighter.

Zachary jumps a little back in surprise, even though he's on the other side of the room. Felix places a hand on his back, rubbing it slowly.

KOTOMI

Well, now I wanna know!

FELIX

It's not that important, really, but basically-

Josephine walks over, putting her hand over Felix's mouth, and he goes quiet.

She reaches into her pocket, taking out a piece of gum that she unwraps and pops into her mouth. She starts to chew it slowly.

JOSEPHINE

It's important for most of us, Felix. But yeah! Basically, this super cool agent dude is in town, and he's trying to find someone to play...

KOTOMI

Oh shit, really? It's been ages since the last one!

JOSEPHINE

I mean, they're kinda here all the time, 'Tomi, you're just always so busy...

Kotomi ignores the comment, watching as Josephine takes her hand off of Felix's mouth and wipes it against her shirt.

KOTOMI

Find someone to play where, anyways?

JOSEPHINE

At the Bowery!

KOTOMI

You're joking.

JOSEPHINE

Nope! And rumor has it, might be a record deal to strike too...

Kotomi runs over to Josephine, her hands gripping tightly to her shoulder. She shakes her furiously.

JOSEPHINE (CONT'D)

Hey, hey, let me finish!

KOTOMI

I need. This. Now.

JOSEPHINE

And so do we all! The opening was on LinkedIn, and all of us signed up already.

KOTOMI
And you didn't tell me?

ZACHARY
We were gonna as soon as you got
here... it's only been ten
minutes...

Kotomi reluctantly sighed, letting go of Josephine to pull out her phone.

She looked at that lock screen again, typing in her passcode to unlock her phone.

She quickly opened the browser, going to LinkedIn and checking around.

KOTOMI
Where do I-?

Josephine grabbed her phone, which got a yelp out of Kotomi. She clicked a few buttons, and handed it back.

Kotomi looked at the listing from an agent named GERARD FLETCHER. His photo was on the page, along with a link to sign up.

JOSEPHINE
Just gotta test your luck! Our
meetings are all coming up pretty
soon, there should be a couple
left.

When Kotomi went to sign up, she could see there was only one time slot left. The rest are marked with "UNAVAILABLE". She checks to see the date of the one available, and her eyes widen.

KOTOMI
That's today.

ZACHARY
Oh, that's a shame...

KOTOMI
Oh fuck no it ain't. I'm going
right now.

JOSEPHINE
Do you even have time?

KOTOMI
Thirty minutes is plenty, long as I
catch the next bus.

JOSEPHINE

Good luck...

Kotomi grabs her backpack and empty guitar case, still holding her guitar under the other arm as she runs up the stairs.

The rest of them watch. Zachary shrugs and goes back to playing the same beat again.

EXT. MIDTOWN MANHATTAN STREETS - DAY

The busy streets of Midtown Manhattan are the same as ever, people crowding the sidewalks and cars constantly stuck in traffic.

A tuft of red hair pokes out from the crowd, which gradually gets more visible as a full head of hair as it sifts through all the people. We see that it's Kotomi, who's running as fast as she can past everyone, heading north.

She has a guitar case on her back which no longer looks empty, and is holding her backpack with one hand.

Despite lack of an expression on her face, some sweat on her forehead and her eyes wide add to the chaos.

She's in the middle of a sidewalk, constantly bumping into people's shoulders and arms as she scurries by.

When she reaches the end of the sidewalk, her backpack knocks into a TALL MAN who almost trips over, dropping his coffee onto the floor. It barely misses hitting Kotomi.

TALL MAN

Look where you're walkin', bitch!
That shit was expensive!

She ignored him, instead staring at the crossing signal. It was stuck on red.

She looked up to the traffic light, which was green.

The tall man continued to stare her down, his voice raising while his face was contorted in deep anger.

TALL MAN (CONT'D)

You gonna pay me back for that?

She continued to ignore him, looking back at the lights.

The crossing signal was still red.

And the traffic light was now yellow.

TALL MAN (CONT'D)
HEY, ARE YOU DEAF OR SOMETHING?

The tall man yelled, his voice devolving to random sounds as he tried to form some semblance of a sentence. He balled his hand into a fist, and raised it towards Kotomi.

She looked back at him, and then quickly whipped her head back towards the traffic light.

It was now red.

Without waiting for the crossing signal, she tightened the hold on her backpack as she ran down the street. The tall man yelled something at her, but the words were muffled by the honking of horns from the cars in the road.

When she reached the other side, the crossing signal went white, with the walking symbol on it. And the crowd started to walk towards her.

The tall man disappeared in the crowd, and it was hard to tell if he'd follow her.

So Kotomi kept running, but as she got further towards her goal, she was met at the end of the sidewalk by a barrier. When she looked up, a crowd of MARATHON RUNNERS brushed past her, running through the street.

Some various crowd members grumbled and started walking left across the sidewalk to get around it.

She froze, looking unsure where to go. She darted her head left, and saw that the barriers went down very far.

She starts to run to the side, heading left down the sidewalk and then towards the street despite the cars coming.

At first, she starts glancing back, but eventually stops.

As she dashes into the street, the cars start to stop abruptly, honking at her. One driver gives her a middle finger, and the one in the car next over screams.

She keeps running until she makes it to the other side of the street, panting.

Her palms are now sweaty, and as she stands by the edge of the sidewalk, she drops her backpack. It splashes into a puddle and gets wet.

She stares at it for a second, then picks it up and continues left. Her backpack drips a trail beside her.

After a second block, she realizes how the marathon keeps going further down, so she then pivots north where the barriers are. She starts running, and...

Once there was a gap in the runners, she hopped over the barrier, running in between them and past them.

One of the runners yelled at her, and she kept moving.

It feels so far away despite only being a single street, moving diagonally to get back to the block she was on before she turned.

She gets close to the end of the other barrier, and hops right over it onto the sidewalk.

She stops to catch her breath again. Up ahead, she sees a sign for a bus stop. And when she looks slightly to the right, the bus is there already.

She lifts her foot to continue to move forward, but when she lowers it, she slips and falls.

As she comes to her senses, she notices the backpack dripped water right where she was standing.

She doesn't bother brushing off her pants, and keeps going. The bus was still there, and just as the last person was loading onto it, she was almost in the line of sight of the driver.

She raised her hand to signal the driver to wait, but midway through raising it...

There's a loud THUD from behind her. The tall man from before knocked right into her, frantically looking around.

Kotomi tumbles to the ground, hitting her left arm against the concrete, catching the rest of her fall with her right hand.

From the large crowd, the tall man didn't notice he knocked over Kotomi. He grunts in frustration and runs past everyone.

When Kotomi looks up, the bus is gone.

INT. LOCAL BAR - DAY

Kotomi walks into a small bar, a lot nicer than the one she played at. The TIRED BARTENDER seems to be busy with a few people sitting by the counter.

Kotomi's backpack is damp, but no longer dripping. She has a scrape on her left arm and her right hand. Her bangs are messy and out of place.

She walks up towards the bar counter, sitting down next to a woman with pink hair. She raises her hand to call over the tired bartender.

TIRED BARTENDER

Looking for something to take
that... all that edge off?

KOTOMI

Yeah, whatever's cheap.

The tired bartender yawns and walks over to start making something. Kotomi starts tapping her finger against the table, which causes the pink haired woman to turn around.

She is ADELINE (20s, pink hair, pastel fashion), a small smile on her face when she looks at Kotomi.

ADELINE

Hey! Someone had a rough day.

KOTOMI

Tell me about it...

Adeline squints, looking Kotomi up and down for a few moments before gasping.

ADELINE

Don't tell me! You're... you're...
wait, don't say anything...

Kotomi leans back just a little while Adeline trails on.

ADELINE (CONT'D)

You're the girl who broke her mic
stand!

For once, Kotomi actually looks shocked.

KOTOMI

Did Josie set you up for this?

ADELINE

Josie?

KOTOMI

Forget it. Just not the first time
I've heard that today.

ADELINE

Yeah, yeah, and then I think we
talked a little after!

KOTOMI

I think I would've remembered
someone with hair like that.

She gestures to her head, circling her left hand around.

ADELINE

I only dyed it yesterday!

KOTOMI

Oh.

ADELINE

Remember, I was telling you how
good your playing was! And the way
you squeezed your pick so hard, it
looked like your fingers might
explode!

KOTOMI

I stopped doing it after that
night, surprisingly.

ADELINE

Because I told you!

KOTOMI

Yeah, because you told me.

ADELINE

Gosh, what a small world. I'm
Adeline, by the way!

She extends her hand, which Kotomi grasps onto, and they
shake hands.

The tired bartender comes back, handing a bottle of beer over
to Kotomi. She takes it, nods, and drinks a sip.

KOTOMI

Kotomi.

ADELINE

Did... did I say something to
bother you?

KOTOMI

No, oh no. Love your energy. Just had the worst day ever, I think?

ADELINE

Oh no, what happened?

KOTOMI

There was this agent I wanted to book, for a show. For musicians, we have to-

ADELINE

You know I play guitar too, right?

KOTOMI

I did not.

ADELINE

Now you do! Why'd you think I was there that night in the first place?

KOTOMI

For fun? Like everyone else?

ADELINE

For fun AND because I played right before you! If you weren't late you would've seen me...

KOTOMI

Well, you know how it is then. Missed my bus, among other things, and I missed my meeting.

ADELINE

Hey, there's always a next time!

Adeline smiles wider, placing a hand on Kotomi's shoulder. It sends a shiver down her spine.

KOTOMI

Not for at least a couple months, with how sought after this guy is. And that's just so long, y'know?

Kotomi takes another sip.

ADELINE

I get it, I get it! Gosh, if something like that happened to me, I'd freak out! Especially when I put all that effort in!

KOTOMI

Yeah, and then what, make a big
stink?

ADELINE

Mhm! And they'll all just give up
because of your overwhelming...
stink?

She laughs, and Kotomi follows with a laugh of her own. The
two of them both look incredibly happy in the moment.

KOTOMI

If I stink, it's the sewer water I
fell in.

ADELINE

Surprisingly, not even a hint of
it!

KOTOMI

Good. That might just get everyone
to clown me instead.

ADELINE

And then you'd have all the reason
to put them in their place!

That gets her to laugh even louder, although Kotomi starts to
quiet herself. Her expression returns to its usual serious
state.

Only Kotomi's expression is visible now. She looks deep in
thought, her eyes slowly widening.

She continues to hold an awkward silence, until Adeline puts
her hand over her own.

ADELINE (CONT'D)

Earth to Kotomi?

KOTOMI

Oh, sorry. Was just thinking about
something.

ADELINE

About what? How much you want my
number?

KOTOMI

You know what? Sure.

INT. TINY APARTMENT - NIGHT

Back in Kotomi's apartment, the same dirty white walls are nothing but mere backdrops against the scene unfolding.

The song "INTO THE VOID" by NINE INCH NAILS is blaring from a small, white speaker, which sits on top of her dresser. The quality is noticeably not pristine, but is still audible.

Kotomi is looking on her phone, back on the website for the booking agent. She scrolls through all eight slots for the next month, which are all still marked as "UNAVAILABLE".

She's humming along to the song as it plays, scrolling back up and then back down, refreshing the page. The page still shows that every slot is booked.

Without much else of a reaction, she puts the phone back down on the bed.

Kotomi does a small dance of sorts as she struts to the other side of her bed, doing a quick spin once she reaches it.

Still humming, she reaches down and grabs a NOTEBOOK from under. It's red but darker than the color of her hair and her guitar, and the front page is worn out. There is a PEN sticking out between the pages. On the front, there's the name "KOTOMI" written with black marker.

She hops back onto her bed, putting the notebook in her lap and grabbing her phone with one of her hands. She goes back to that website, and clicks the back button until she's back on LinkedIn.

When she's on the agent's LinkedIn page, she searches for the mutual connections button. Here, she sees a list of names that include her friends: "Josephine Blackwood", "Zachary Waters", and "Felix Creed". Among those are a handful of seven other names.

She opens her notebook to the page where the pen was sticking out, which has some messily written writing on it. It seems to be lyrics to a song, although she flips past the page too quickly to see.

She keeps flipping through, but every page is filled until the very last one. She stops humming, grumbles, and throws the notebook across the room.

She starts humming again, getting up and dancing again, looking down at the mess on the floor. Besides the clothes, there's a few pens, markers, guitar picks, and takeout menus. She reaches down, picking up a BLACK MARKER.

She nearly jumps over to the nearest wall, looking at it for a second. At first, she seems reluctant, but then turns more determined as she writes in big letters high up on the wall, "TARGETS".

Underneath, she starts writing out names, in a list format. Only first names are used, with the names as shown:

"JOSEPHINE", "ZACHARY", "FELIX", "DAPHNE", "KILLIAN", "JACKSON", "CARRIE", "MAKOA", "AIKO", and "ACACIA".

Once each one is written down, a quick montage begins of her writing details down for each name.

With abbreviations and shorthand writing, she starts putting details of possible whereabouts, while also checking their LinkedIn for the work they're doing.

When she gets to Josephine, she hesitates, and then continues. She also hesitates on Zachary and Felix.

For "DAPHNE", "AIKO", and "ACACIA", the word "OLD" is written next to them, among other indecipherable abbreviations.

For "KILLIAN" and "JACKSON", the word "USUAL" is written next to them, among other indecipherable abbreviations.

For "CARRIE" and "MAKOA", there are question marks next to their names, and some other abbreviations still.

For her three friends, the word "CONTACT" is written next to them.

Once the montage is over and all her writing is done, she sits back on her bed facing it, admiring the work. She looks down and realizes she wrote it all with a Sharpie, although she doesn't do more than shrug.

After a brief pause, she takes a deep breath, but is interrupted by her phone ringing, which sounds like a cover instrumental version of "OBSTACLE 1" by INTERPOL.

She looks at the phone, and sees the contact name...

Josephine.

She picks up the phone up, holding it close.

KOTOMI
Josie, what's up?

EXT. CENTRAL PARK - NIGHT

Josephine is sitting at a park bench, her feet swinging in the air while she holds the phone to her ear, smiling wide.

JOSEPHINE

'Tomi! How ya doin'? Did you get the spot?

INTERCUT KOTOMI AND JOSEPHINE

KOTOMI

Nah. Some dude literally knocked me over.

JOSEPHINE

You're joking!

KOTOMI

Wish I was.

JOSEPHINE

Well, ain't that a shame? Guess you'll needa wait!

KOTOMI

My favorite activity.

JOSEPHINE

Well, in the meantime, wanna hang tomorrow?

KOTOMI

Double shift.

JOSEPHINE

They fuckin' let you take double shifts at TACO BELL???

KOTOMI

If you beg enough.

JOSEPHINE

Shame... guess next time we see each other, might be at the Ballroom!

KOTOMI

Making it like we can't just hang the day after?

JOSEPHINE

Well, my meeting's tomorrow, silly!
And I know I'm gonna beat all the
other fuckers who try. Don't tell
Zach or Felix I said that though.

Kotomi pauses, looking deep in thought before she speaks.

KOTOMI

You know... I guess I wouldn't mind
doing something.

JOSEPHINE

What about the double shift?

KOTOMI

I can always push it back. I wanna
help you practice before the big
day.

JOSEPHINE

You think the agent's gonna want me
to play or something?

KOTOMI

You never know.

JOSEPHINE

Fair! I'll see you tomorrow then!
Where to?

KOTOMI

You choose.

JOSEPHINE

Central Park? It's so nice out
here!

KOTOMI

Sounds like a plan.

JOSEPHINE

Deal! See you then!

END OF INTERCUT

The phone hangs up, and Kotomi looks back towards the wall,
right at Josephine's name.

EXT. SOUTH END CENTRAL PARK - DAY

Kotomi is sitting by a bench, looking back at the Christopher
Columbus statue that's near the entrance of the park.

She has her guitar case and backpack next to her on the bench, and she's tapping her foot repeatedly against the dirt vaguely to the same rhythm as "INTO THE VOID" from before.

At first there's nobody but a few pedestrians walking past her. And then, there's a rustle behind her.

Out pops Josephine, who goes from peeking from behind the bench to jumping out and running in front of her.

JOSEPHINE

Boo!

KOTOMI

Ooh, scary.

Josephine has her own guitar case strapped across her back, same yellow as before. Putting her PHONE on the bench, she unzips her case, taking out the same yellow bass guitar from before. It's obnoxiously bright as it shines against the sunlight.

JOSEPHINE

I only have a little bit, but I'm glad I could see you!

KOTOMI

If I can't get in, then at least you better. It'll be a win for the both of us.

JOSEPHINE

Haha, that's the spirit! Come on, let's get this goin'.

Kotomi nods, unzipping her own guitar, which she holds properly in position. Her right hand reaches into the pocket of her shorts, which we see something poking out...

It looks like the end of a pair of SCISSORS. She digs past it, grabbing her pick instead.

She takes a deep breath, her hand shaking ever so slightly.

KOTOMI

Did you have something in mind?

JOSEPHINE

I dunno what'd impress him...

KOTOMI

Something that doesn't break his eardrums, hopefully?

JOSEPHINE

That's the fun part though!

KOTOMI

How about take that and just lower it a couple decibels. Or a couple dozen.

JOSEPHINE

It's not like I have an amp anyways.

KOTOMI

Perfect. Then you just need to play something... complicated, maybe?

Josephine nods, grabbing her own pick from her pocket that's the exact same yellow as the bass guitar. She grins, before strumming a quick chord. It's quiet and acoustic.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)

A little more than that.

One of Kotomi's hands grabs the neck of her guitar, and the other hovers near that same pocket.

Josephine doesn't notice, as she looks deep in thought. She eventually starts strumming a few chords in very fast succession, playing a lovely but energetic tune.

Kotomi nods along to the beat, her eyes darting everywhere but Josephine.

She looks at the people walking by, the birds in the sky, her backpack on the side, and her own guitar.

Josephine keeps going, speeding up her tune. Her fingers are moving really fast, and she seems to be somehow keeping up.

Kotomi sways her feet, still looking away. When Josephine finishes, her hand drops, and she shakes it violently.

JOSEPHINE

God... that takes a lot out of me!

KOTOMI

Sounded pretty damn good though.

JOSEPHINE

Got any tips?

Kotomi brings her hand back to the guitar, and strums one of the chords that Josephine played. Josephine leans in, looking closely.

KOTOMI
When you did this one, try
repeating it before you go up the
scale. Like this.

She repeats the chord twice in quick succession, before
moving up to the next one Josephine had played.

JOSEPHINE
Wait... you might be onto
something!

Josephine hesitates for a second, flexing her fingers before
trying to copy the tune Kotomi just played. She seems to be a
lot slower than before, though.

KOTOMI
You okay?

Josephine stops.

JOSEPHINE
My hand's so cramped!

Kotomi's hand starts to gravitate back towards her pocket,
her voice a little nervous.

KOTOMI
When that happens, I usually run my
hand under warm water...

JOSEPHINE
Can you hold my guitar for a minute
then? I'll run off to the nearest
fountain!

Kotomi nods, and Josephine passes her guitar over. Kotomi
puts her own one to the side, grabbing Josephine's.

Josephine runs off, leaving Kotomi alone on the bench.

She stares at Josephine's guitar in her hands, looking around
the park to make sure she's nowhere in sight. And when she
confirms that, she takes the scissors out.

She takes the scissors in her hands, hovering over the
strings. The blades hover near the leftmost string.

She stops, waiting, and takes a deep breath. She hesitates
for a few moments, and then slowly closes the scissors in on
the string.

The blades are now super close to touching the string, and
her breathing gets heavier.

Her hands shake profusely, and just when she's about to cut it...

Josephine is running back, panting.

JOSEPHINE (CONT'D)
Ah, sorry! Left my-

Kotomi is holding the scissors next to her head, the blades surrounding a piece of her hair.

JOSEPHINE (CONT'D)
What are you-?

She cuts it, watching the tuft of hair fall to the ground.

KOTOMI
It was bothering me. Had to do it.

Josephine looks at her confused, before reaching to grab her phone on the bench.

JOSEPHINE
You do you girl...

Josephine runs back out of sight. And once she does, Kotomi brings the scissors back to the string, her hands shaky.

She forces her hand still, and starts to cut into the string.

She stops before it chops off fully. With the cut made, the string is barely holding on.

She hesitates, before doing it to the next string. And then the next. Until each one has a small cut in them.

She quickly scrambles and puts the scissors right back in her pocket.

And right when they go away, Josephine is running back with damp hands.

JOSEPHINE (CONT'D)
Surprisingly better! Lemme try again now, watch this.

KOTOMI
Give it a go.

She hands the guitar back, her hands shaking even more now. She hides them behind her back.

Josephine takes the guitar, holding her pick close to the strings. As soon as she strums it a couple times, trying to keep that fast pace...

...all the strings break in half, hanging from the guitar.

Josephine screams, nearly dropping her guitar.

JOSEPHINE

What the hell happened?

Kotomi pretends to be shocked, her voice raising

KOTOMI

Oh no! What the fuck???

JOSEPHINE

No, no... how am I supposed to...

KOTOMI

Shit, shit... is that even possible?

JOSEPHINE

I don't know... I... I need to get this fixed now! But then...

KOTOMI

Is there even a point in going?

JOSEPHINE

It's still worth a shot!

Stuttering, Josephine grabs her guitar tightly, trying to grab some of the strings before they graze against the ground.

Kotomi waves as Josephine runs off. Kotomi is left alone again, and at first, she has no reaction.

But slowly, a smile forms on her face.

INT. APARTMENT STAIRWELL - NIGHT

The sounds of footsteps and giggling echo within the stairwell, along with muffled conversation that can't quite be made out.

Kotomi and Adeline emerge, running up the stairs, going higher and higher until they reach the very top where the door is. Adeline noticeably has a BANDAGE on her upper arm.

The door opens, and they reach the roof.

EXT. APARTMENT ROOF - CONTINUOUS

The two run out into the breeze, Kotomi looking up in the sky. It's cloudy and hard to see much.

KOTOMI

I expected a better view from how eager you were to bring me here.

ADELINE

Look, look! Right up there!

Adeline points up high, pointing at a normal looking cloud.

ADELINE (CONT'D)

It's star-shaped! I see it here every night!

KOTOMI

Hmm... a star blob, maybe?

ADELINE

Same thing!

KOTOMI

Reminds me of you.

ADELINE

I'm a blob?

KOTOMI

No. Because you'll be a star one day... I'm sure of it.

ADELINE

Oh, please... that's you!

KOTOMI

Y'know, maybe that's right. That stage is practically calling my name.

Kotomi pulls out her phone, and when she turns it on, it's already on the agent's booking page. She refreshes it, and every slot is still "UNAVAILABLE". She quickly slots it in her pocket again.

ADELINE

Someone's pumped! Have I inspired you enough yet?

KOTOMI

Think so. I think it's that smile.

Adeline smiles wide, and the two of them chuckle. They share a silent moment, gazes locked until Adeline speaks up, pointing to Kotomi's hair where she cut it before.

ADELINE

What happened to your-?

KOTOMI

It's the new style. You dig it?

ADELINE

It's definitely different! Maybe
I'm not up to date on the new
trends... but I do know this!

Adeline gestures Kotomi to follow her, and the two of them walk to the edge of the roof, where a makeshift ramp is made with wooden planks.

Adeline lies down on the ramp, and Kotomi reluctantly joins her.

ADELINE (CONT'D)

Now we can see the clouds better!

Adeline reaches her hand out towards her, and Kotomi looks over. She notices the bandage on her arm, and then grabs her hand. They intertwine fingers.

KOTOMI

You scrape your arm or something?

ADELINE

Oh, no, no... kitchen accident.

KOTOMI

That's one unlucky kitchen
accident.

ADELINE

Y-yeah.

The two sit in silence for a moment.

KOTOMI

Thank you for hanging out with me.
I wasn't lying when I said that
smile helped... a lot. Made this
week a little more bearable.

ADELINE

Of course! It's the least I can do.
And if it gets you back into the
groove of things, we can hang out
all the time!

KOTOMI

I think I'd like that.

ADELINE

I used to come out here a lot when
I was a little kid. Always liked
trying to count the clouds. And
then I'd fall asleep!

KOTOMI

You lived here as a kid?

ADELINE

Yep! I'm not in the same apartment
as my parents anymore, but same
building!

KOTOMI

New York City never really lets you
leave, does it?

Adeline turns her head to face Kotomi, and they lock eyes.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)

Not that I'm complaining.

ADELINE

I'm really glad I could show this
to you. Makes my heart happy.

KOTOMI

I might be the happiest girl alive
right now.

The two share a glance, and the clouds continue to pass them
by.

INT. SMALL BAR - DAY

Kotomi is at the usual bar, looking at the microphone stand
that she was next to a few days previous. On the stage was
DAPHNE (20's, casual fashion), who just finished performing
and was stepping down.

Kotomi glanced at her phone again, refreshing the page on the
agent's page. Everything was listed as "UNAVAILABLE", with
the slot Josephine had no longer visible.

When Daphne walks in Kotomi's direction, she doesn't notice her and continues past her. Kotomi puts her phone away, and blinks a few times.

Kotomi strides faster, walking ahead of her, and barely turns in her direction. Right when Daphne is about to go past her again, Kotomi barely slides her boot in front of her.

Daphne's foot collides with it, and loses her balance, toppling right over in front of Kotomi. There's a loud THUD and CRACK when her arm hits the ground. Kotomi pulls her foot back, and her expression goes nervous.

Kotomi stops for a second. She stares at the impacted arm.

She looks for far too long.

And then she walks away.

Here begins a montage where Kotomi is interacting with her different targets. Later after, she's sitting at the bar counter next to KILLIAN (20's, beard), who gets up and excuses himself for the bathroom while leaving his phone on the counter.

Kotomi looks both ways, before sliding the phone into her pocket. She gets up and walks outside, glancing behind her.

She opens the phone. It asks for a pin.

She types in random numbers until it locks out.

She slides the phone near the entrance on the sidewalk.

Later, she's chatting with JACKSON (20's, curly hair) while leaning against a wall.

KOTOMI

Carrie was talkin' shit about ya, dude.

JACKSON

What'd she say?

KOTOMI

Said you play like a pussy.

JACKSON

I don't play like a pussy!

Jackson runs in a fit of rage, finding CARRIE (20's, pale). Jackson starts to yell indecipherably at her, and the two of them start to escalate and leave the bar.

Later, Kotomi is walking past a blue guitar laying against a wall near the microphone stand. Looking both ways, she quickly kneels, turning one of the tuning pegs further and further.

And then she does the same to the next one.

And the next one.

She gets up and walks back towards the heart of the bar when she hears footsteps. MAKOA (20's, long hair) walks over and grabs the guitar before going up to the top of the platform.

Kotomi watches among the rest of the small crowd as Makoa clears his throat, plugging in the amplifier and getting ready to play.

Makoa starts playing, and after the first riff, he pauses in confusion at the weird sound. He stops to pluck each individual string, and when he reaches the top-most one, it snaps.

The next follow in unison. There are gasps.

Later, Kotomi is at the bar counter talking to AIKO (20's, elegant fashion), the two smiling and chatting.

AIKO

You'd really do that?

KOTOMI

Dogs are my favorite animal. Lemme give you my number, and you can message me when you want me to watch him.

Aiko nods and passes over her phone, which Kotomi fumbles around with as she heads to the contact app. Before she does, she swipes quickly to the REMINDER app, where she sees one in two hours for "MEETING". She deletes it.

She puts her phone number in the contact with name "KOTOMI", and hands it back.

Later, Kotomi is passing by the bar, where she sees ACACIA (20's, freckles) sipping on a colorful drink. There's noticeably a small bag of POWDERED DRUG near Acacia on the table, left alone. When the glass is in Acacia's hand, Kotomi takes a deep breath.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)

Ow, fuck!

Kotomi screams at the top of her lungs before tripping over seemingly nothing and falling face forward onto the floor.

The noise is so loud that it startles everyone around her, including Acacia, who drops her glass from flinching. It falls right into her lap, the drink spilling all over her clothes.

She turns around, worried.

ACACIA
Are you...?

KOTOMI
Thought I saw a tarantula.

EXT. OUTSIDE SMALL BAR - CONTINUOUS

Kotomi is strolling outside on the sidewalk by the bar, the sky dark around her. When the bar is out of sight, she leans against a window in front of a coffee shop. She lets out a large sigh, pulling out her phone to read a text message.

It's from Zachary, and it says "Party tomorrow don't forget".

She reaches into her pocket, pulling out that same packet of powdered drug she seemingly swiped. She quickly puts it away.

EXT. OUTSIDE OF PARTY VENUE - NIGHT

Kotomi is wearing a black BACKPACK on her back, donning a white shirt with "NIN" on the front, walking up to a green door in the middle of a street of apartment complexes. On the door is a paper flyer for a party that's supposedly inside. She opens the door.

INT. VENUE STAIRCASE - CONTINUOUS

She enters into a large staircase, which she quickly steps down. At the bottom is another door, which is accompanied by a BOUNCER. Faint music could be heard through the walls.

KOTOMI
Zach invited me.

BOUNCER
You Josephine?

KOTOMI
No. She said she was too sad to
make it. I'm Kotomi.

BOUNCER
Oh, yeah. Okay.

The bouncer opens the door, and she walks through.

INT. PARTY VENUE - CONTINUOUS

Inside seems to be an apartment transformed into a party space, a large crowd formed in the middle of the apparent living room. LED lights line the walls near the ceiling, different colors in different spots. Most people have cups in their hands, and there's someone by the kitchen area serving drinks. There's also a DJ in the corner playing electronic mixes of rock music.

Kotomi walks through the crowd, bumping into a few people as she navigates to find Zachary. She spots him off to the side with Felix, and they seem to be whispering to each other.

KOTOMI
Hey guys, miss me?

They cease their whispering, Zachary turning with a smile.

ZACHARY
Always. I'm glad you could make it.

KOTOMI
I'll do a lot for free drinks.

The two of them laugh.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)
But yeah, it's pretty nice what you got going on.

ZACHARY
Of course. Gotta thank Felix for that, though.

Felix smiles, waving his hand in front of himself.

FELIX
No, no, it was all your idea, dear.

ZACHARY
As if.

KOTOMI
I'm gonna go grab a drink if you wanna talk for a bit.

Zachary nods, and starts following Kotomi as she walks towards the kitchen area. Felix follows behind him, and the three hover by the counter.

The PUNK BARTENDER looks over at her, extending her hand out. She takes it, shaking it.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)

The fanciest thing you can make.

The punk bartender chuckles, going to grab a bottle of something colorful before pouring it into a glass and sliding it over to Kotomi.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)

And for my lovely friends too.
Whatever they like.

FELIX

Whiskey sour for the both of us.

The punk bartender gets to work on both cocktails.

ZACHARY

Wish Josie could've made it. She
would've loved the chaos.

KOTOMI

Did it really go that badly?

ZACHARY

I mean, didn't she tell you?

KOTOMI

She told me she didn't get it.

FELIX

Apparently, she was accused of bad
conduct.

KOTOMI

From broken strings?

ZACHARY

She broke her strings?

KOTOMI

Y-yeah, she told me that too.

ZACHARY

Maybe that's what got her to act
out...

KOTOMI

Yeah.

The two whiskey sours are placed in front of Zachary and Felix, and Zachary starts to sip his.

ZACHARY

What about you though? Did the guy say anything when you met with him?

KOTOMI

I missed my chance.

FELIX

Shame.

KOTOMI

Always a next time, though.

FELIX

Maybe the guy is just cursed. Daphne told me she broke her arm and missed it too.

KOTOMI

Daphne applied?

ZACHARY

I think a lot of people did...

Kotomi takes a couple sips of her own drink, seemingly thinking again. Her hand drifts into her pocket mindlessly, and then rests on the table.

KOTOMI

Anyone brought...?

ZACHARY

Yeah, Kane has the pot. You want some?

FELIX

Sweetheart, you know what I told you...

ZACHARY

It's a party. Let us have a little fun.

KOTOMI

Yeah Felix, let us have a little fun!

FELIX

At least it's just weed...

Zachary stands up, walking off into the crowd. Felix waits a second before following him. Both of their drinks are left on the table.

PUNK BARTENDER

They're always attached at the hip.
Think they're a thing?

KOTOMI

I'd be more surprised if someone
said they were just roommates. Oh,
you know where the bathroom is?

The punk bartender points to the right, and Kotomi quickly jumps up and runs with urgency past everyone to the bathroom.

INT. PARTY BATHROOM - CONTINUOUS

She enters, closing and locking the door. Opening her backpack, she slips out a black hoodie, putting it over her shirt. She puts the hood up, and reaches back into her pocket to pull out the powdered drug in the small bag.

Her hands shake, and she coughs loudly. Clearing her throat, she walks over to the sink, and another cough causes a small amount of blood to fall out of her mouth.

She looks at it in disgust and worry before rushing out of the bathroom, leaving her backpack behind.

INT. PARTY VENUE - CONTINUOUS

Kotomi finds her way back to the counter where Zachary and Felix are still gone, the bag of powder hiding in her palm. She glances deeper into the crowd, where the two seem to be talking to someone else and negotiating over a bag of weed.

Pulling her hood further over her head, she opens the bag while it's inside her pocket. She looks over at the punk bartender, who is occupied and turned around towards the various bottles.

Once the bag is opened, her hand leaves her pocket.

She holds it over Zachary's drink, and starts walking past it.

She sprinkles some of the powder inside, spiking it.

Once most of the bag is used, she puts the bag back inside her pocket and tries to casually walk towards the exit. She finds it, and opens the door to walk out.

INT. VENUE STAIRCASE - CONTINUOUS

She scrambles past the bouncer, who gives her a suspicious look as she rushes up the stairs to leave the place.

EXT. OUTSIDE OF PARTY VENUE - CONTINUOUS

Once she makes it out, she catches her breath off to the side of the door, coughing again. The door creaks open, although she doesn't notice.

Just as she's about to walk off, she feels a hand on her shoulder. She doesn't turn around, but hears a voice.

FELIX

Think you'll roofie someone and get away with it?

From Felix's angle, it's hard to tell who it is from the hood. His hand moves to pull the hood, but before he can, Kotomi runs off.

EXT. MANHATTAN STREETS - CONTINUOUS

Kotomi immediately bolts as fast as she can, not looking behind her as she looks around for a way to hide. In front of her, the street is relatively empty except for a few people, but the block ahead seems to be more crowded.

Running for that block, Felix is close behind her, his face ridden with anger.

Kotomi dashes past the street, disappearing into the crowd, and she's nowhere to be found. Felix yells in frustration and pulls out his phone to make a call.

FELIX

Looking for someone with a black hoodie. Spiked Zach's drink.

He puts his phone back in his pocket, and starts running into the crowd himself.

Out of the crowd emerges a figure wearing a green jacket, who we can see is Kotomi. Once she disperses from the crowd and turns the corner, there's screaming from the people behind her, notably a DISGRUNTLED MAN.

DISGRUNTLED MAN
My jacket!

Kotomi continues west from the corner, and ahead of her are many large screens. She's now in Times Square.

EXT. TIMES SQUARE - CONTINUOUS

The crowds are denser, many vendors on the sides of the streets, and various costumed performers holding signs and taking photos with people.

She runs into the middle of a crowd, and looks up and around. The lights from all the screens illuminate the night, and it feels like they're all point at her.

As she looks around all 360 degrees, she notices a few MEN IN SUITS in the corner of her eye that seem to be looking around. And past that...

She sees Felix's hair pointing out near a few others blocking him. Wasting no time, she runs onto the sidewalk and keeps going.

She passes by a VENDOR selling glasses and costume accessories, grabbing a PURGE MASK and putting it on while she runs by. The vendor points at her but doesn't chase.

Looking to her side, she notices the men in suits still around. To avoid them, she ducks to her left into the nearest store.

INT. I LOVE NY GIFT SHOP - CONTINUOUS

The bell rings from the door as she runs in, the few customers not paying much attention as she hides behind a rotating shelf of "I LOVE NEW YORK" t-shirts.

Finally having a moment, she takes a breath, and the store owner glances over at her. She looks back at him, giving him a thumbs up. She then peeks out from the shelf.

She instantly sees Felix passing by. And right when he turns his head towards her...

She doesn't make any eye contact before running towards the back of the store. Some of the customers get caught in the commotion, trying to grab her as if she stole something.

But she makes it to the back, and slams her knee into a door marked "STAFF". It doesn't budge.

She slams her fist into it next. It creaks open, and she runs inside.

INT. I LOVE NY GIFT SHOP STAFF ROOM - CONTINUOUS

There isn't much in here but boxes labeled with different types of merchandise, and one woman smoking in a corner. Her eyes widen when she sees Kotomi run by, but doesn't say a word.

Kotomi closes the door she went through, grabbing a nearby box and sliding it in front to barricade it. She hears a knock against the door, and some faint yelling.

Ignoring it, she looks for the exit, seeing a door at the other end with the big "EXIT" sign. As she runs to it...

She trips over glasses shaped like the letters N and Y, and as she tumbles to the ground, she catches herself against a nearby shelf with her hand. The edge of the shelf catches onto the green jacket.

She tugs at it, a ripping noise heard as she gets free, but doesn't pay attention to it.

She knocks away the glasses with her boot and then starts limping over to the exit door, pushing it open.

EXT. BACK OF GIFT SHOP - CONTINUOUS

She's met with the usual polluted air, but it's fresher than the shop she was in as she walks outside. Looking to her right is an alleyway, and to her left shows more streets and people.

She turns left, but sees a man in a suit walking over to her. Knowing she was wearing a disguise, she tries to play it cool.

KOTOMI

Hey sir, do I know you?

The man starts to gain speed. She reaches her hand out in front of her, now noticing the sleeve of the green jacket was torn off, exposing the black hoodie underneath.

She turns around behind her and runs to the right where the alleyway was.

At the end is a fence, which she grabs onto, and starts climbing.

Some loose wire ends of the fence scratch her hands, but she makes distance by hopping onto some stacked boxes left out here.

The man in the suit catches up to her, tugging at her boot.

She shakes him off, and tosses herself over the fence, thudding to the ground.

Groaning, she slowly rises to her feet, and keeps running. The man in the suit looks at her, shaking his head, and pulls out his phone.

Kotomi doesn't stop running until she's back in the street again. When she turns her head to the right, she spots another man in a suit. She runs off left and disappears into the next alleyway she finds.

INT. DARK ALLEYWAY - CONTINUOUS

The alleyway is dark, secluded, and away from everything else. As she runs towards the back, there's the grimy feeling of discarded trash, an old dumpster, and cobwebs that make the place look untouched for years.

Kotomi is pacing once she reaches the back, stepping over a cobweb and drifting to behind the dumpster. Her breathing starts off sporadic, and quickly grows heavy.

She rips the mask off, exposing her wide eyes, open mouth, and sweat covering her forehead.

She throws the mask right into the dumpster, before taking off the green hoodie frantically. That goes in the dumpster next.

Hesitating, she slips off the black hoodie, throwing it away next. What's left is a shell of the same woman who went out of her way to try and sabotage Zachary, and she looks distraught as can be.

The cars on the nearby street sound louder than ever. The moon seems to shine on her brighter than any light, like it'd expose her to the people looking for her any second. She hears distant yelling, and it sounds like it could be directed at her.

Her hands rise, and she lowers her head and buries it into her palms. Her hands are noticeably shaking, and her breathing isn't improving.

She slowly sinks to the floor, her knees bending as her back slides against the nearby concrete wall. When she reaches the floor, small tears start to form.

She coughs, lowering her hands to give her room to breath better. She tries to take a whiff of the air, but is struggling.

Her hand rests on her chest, and for a moment, her gaze looks disoriented, almost as if she's disassociating.

FLASHBACK TO:

INT. CHILDHOOD LIVING ROOM - DAY

We see two adults, Kotomi's parents (middle-aged), scolding a young Kotomi.

KOTOMI'S DAD
Stop trying to play! You'll never
be good enough!

BACK TO PRESENT

Kotomi finally gets a breath, her hand now rubbing against her forehead.

FLASHBACK TO:

INT. SMALL BAR - DAY

We're back at the bar where Kotomi talked to Zachary, Josephine, and Felix about their careers from the beginning.

JOSEPHINE
Then just go do it already!

BACK TO PRESENT

Kotomi tries to get up, stumbling as she grabs onto the dumpster.

FLASHBACK TO:

INT. LOCAL BAR - DAY

Back in the bar with Adeline when she met her for the first time in years.

ADELINE

And then you'd have all the reason
to put them in their place!

BACK TO PRESENT

Heaving, Kotomi clutches her stomach. She looks like she's about to puke, but tries to take a few steps forward.

Her body frozen in place, expecting to vomit. But she doesn't.

She breaks out of her trance, reaching the entrance to the alleyway, peeking her head out.

There's a few men in suits at the end of the block, but far away from the alleyway.

Not wasting any time, she bolts out from the alleyway, running the opposite direction from them.

EXT. OUTSIDE APARTMENT COMPLEX - LATER

Kotomi, out of breath, is ringing the button in front of Adeline's apartment complex. A voice comes through the speaker.

ADELINE (V.O.)

Who is this?

KOTOMI

Me. Uh, Kotomi

ADELINE (V.O.)

Oh! 'Kay!

There's a buzzing sound, and the door opens. Kotomi rushes inside.

INT. APARTMENT COMPLEX - CONTINUOUS

Kotomi heads straight for the elevator. She presses the button a few times, and no elevator opens. Immediately, she bolts for the stairs.

INT. APARTMENT STAIRWELL - CONTINUOUS

She's back at that same stairwell from before, although she only goes up two flights before heading through a door.

INT. APARTMENT COMPLEX 2ND FLOOR - CONTINUOUS

Kotomi runs to a door with a pink heart at the front. She rings the doorbell, and is greeted by Adeline. She has messy hair, wearing a tank top and looks like she just got out of bed. She still has that same bandage on her arm.

ADELINE

It's good to see you... but why-?

KOTOMI

Bathroom...

Kotomi covers her hand with her mouth, and Adeline lets her in, although confused.

INT. ADELINE'S APARTMENT - CONTINUOUS

Adeline's waiting by the kitchen in her apartment, which is only slightly larger than Kotomi's. The walls are painted a light red, bright fluorescent lights illuminating the whole room. There's a few comic book figures on a shelf in the living room, along with some various manga.

Adeline is pouring a couple glasses of water. Kotomi slowly emerges from the bathroom, her face and hands damp, sighing as she walks up to the counter.

KOTOMI

Sorry for the sudden notice.

ADELINE

It's fine, I'm just... confused?

KOTOMI

Can't blame you. It's just been a terrible night. Needed to see you.

ADELINE

Aww...

Adeline reaches her hand across the table, grabbing onto Kotomi's. She brushes her finger against the back of her hand to try and soothe her.

ADELINE (CONT'D)

That's adorable, really.

KOTOMI

Yeah, I'm so adorable right now.

Kotomi glances down at the scratches on her palm. Luckily, she didn't break enough skin to bleed.

ADELINE
Did you fall or something?

KOTOMI
Yeah. Times Square is no joke.

ADELINE
That's why I never go there!

Adeline laughs, sliding a glass of water across the table.

ADELINE (CONT'D)
Drink up.

Kotomi nods, taking the glass and drinking a few small sips.

KOTOMI
Thanks a bunch. Did I wake you?

ADELINE
Almost! Couldn't sleep though, so it's fine. I'm more worried about you, though! You came in here like you saw a ghost! You couldn't have just fallen...

KOTOMI
Can we not talk about... that... for the night? Just anything else.

ADELINE
Okay, okay.

Adeline walks over to her couch, plopping down. She lays her legs out against the small table in front, which looks scratched but overall intact. Kotomi takes her glass, walking over...

Before she sits down, she notices a BRUISE sticking out next to the tank top strap on her shoulder. Not saying anything, she sits down, placing her glass on the table.

KOTOMI
So... anything new?

ADELINE
Got the girl I like to come over to my house?

KOTOMI
Besides that, silly.

ADELINE

Oh, come on! This isn't an every day thing! Lemme boast a little bit!

Adeline moves a little closer to Kotomi, nuzzling her shoulder against the other before giggling. Kotomi catches another glance of the bruise, and then looks at the bandage again.

KOTOMI

Don't tell me you had another kitchen accident.

ADELINE

Oh, it's the same one!

KOTOMI

Did you fall and cut yourself at the same time?

There's a pause between the two of them.

ADELINE

It's nothing... really.

KOTOMI

Doesn't sound like nothing.

Kotomi cups the side of Adeline's face with her hand, looking at her in the eyes. Like she found something new to distract herself with.

ADELINE

Can you kiss me first?

Kotomi is lost for words, her face flushing red as she tries to find a response.

ADELINE (CONT'D)

I promise to tell you after!

KOTOMI

Could've just asked normally.

A small smile curls on her lips before she closes her eyes, leaning in to kiss her. Adeline yelps, before closing her own eyes. For that moment, they share the purest love.

When Kotomi pulls back, she lets out a satisfied sigh.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)

Wish I did that much earlier.

ADELINE
Telling me you wanted it?

KOTOMI
Why wouldn't I? Have you looked at
yourself?

ADELINE
Yeah, but I'm usually too busy
looking at you.

Kotomi's hand lowers itself from Adeline's face, resting on
her shoulder now instead.

KOTOMI
So, what's going on?

ADELINE
Well.

Adeline pauses, her smile quickly fading.

ADELINE (CONT'D)
My parents aren't... the fondest of
my career path.

KOTOMI
Sounds familiar.

ADELINE
They live in the same building, so
I visit them sometimes. And my dad
wasn't so happy when I told him I
found a way to get money playing.
He still doesn't believe it'll do
anything good.

Kotomi doesn't respond, although her face grows to a much
warmer expression as she listens. She rubs her shoulder
slowly, almost massaging it.

ADELINE (CONT'D)
But it's not the end of the world.
As long as I succeed, what does it
matter what they think?

KOTOMI
That's a good mindset.

Kotomi pecks her cheek with another small kiss. Adeline's
face lights up again.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)
What'd you find anyways?

ADELINE

Oh! Remember the Ballroom thing you told me about?

KOTOMI

Yeah...

Kotomi starts to look a little nervous.

ADELINE

I decided to check since you told me about it, and the other day I saw there was a spot opened! And thought I'd give it a chance!

Kotomi is silent, in shock for a moment, before breaking into nervous laughter.

KOTOMI

T-that's amazing.

Adeline giggles, wrapping her arms around her neck and dragging her over to her. The two of them topple onto the couch, Kotomi looking down at her.

ADELINE

When I get up there, you'll come watch me, right?

KOTOMI

Of course I will.

As Adeline pulls her into another kiss, Kotomi's eyes look full of dread before they close, her body language tense before relaxing into the embrace they share.

INT. TINY APARTMENT - DAY

Kotomi's apartment is somehow messier than before, littered with more various objects all over the floor. The pill bottle for her disease is lying next to her dresser, but seemed to have fell down at some point. It's not empty.

Kotomi is sitting at the edge of her bed, dangling her feet as she writes in her notebook. She's writing lyrics for a song of her own.

They seem to be generally pretty sad lines, but mainly just random words instead of coherent sentences. It's clearly still in the drafting process.

She throws her book to the side, and walks over to grab her guitar. Still standing, she hoists the strap over herself, taking a guitar pick from on top of her dresser.

She looks down and notices the pill bottle. She looks back to her guitar, ignoring it.

Unplugged, she strums a few of her strings, the acoustic sound low and barely reverberating through the room.

She tries playing a chord, which she likes the sound of, before moving an octave up. She tries playing that one, shaking her head.

And for the next few moments, she starts to compose a small chord progression. While doing so, there's a sound behind her. It's a distant voice.

DISTANT VOICE

Kotomi, what are you doing?

Kotomi turns around, and...

She seems to be in a completely new place, in some sort of dream.

INT. CHILDHOOD BEDROOM - CONTINUOUS

A present day Kotomi is standing inside what appears to be a room decorated by a child. There's various posters on the wall for different bands and album covers, school supplies scattered about a table by a desk that has a smiling picture of a sun plastered against the wall behind it.

She scoffs upon seeing the sun, and turns to where the voice was coming from. It appears to be Kotomi's MOM, who has a stern look on her face.

MOM

That ruckus is disrupting the whole house.

At first, Kotomi appears as if she's about to yell at her, but quickly her expression devolves into something sad. Something scared.

KOTOMI

I... I'll be quieter, sorry...

Her mom shakes her head, walking closer to her. Kotomi takes a step back.

MOM
Did you even finish your homework?
You know the rule.

KOTOMI
I did...

MOM
Let me have a look.

Her mom walks over to the desk, looking at the various papers scattered. She picks up one, reading it.

MOM (CONT'D)
Your handwriting got worse.

KOTOMI
My hand was cramped, sorry-

MOM
Making the same excuses.

KOTOMI
My playing's gotten better, and-

She's cut off by a stern look, that quickly turns to indifference.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)
If you'll just let me show you what
I've been working on...

MOM
I'll look at your homework later.

KOTOMI
Wait! Wait, please, just...

The mom turns towards the doorway, walking a few steps.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)
Just give me a chance, please? I
promise it's good...

Silence. And then...

MOM
(under her breath)
If only she wasn't... like this.

A pause.

Kotomi bursts into tears.

She turns around to look away from her mom. And when she does, she's somewhere else entirely again.

INT. CHILDHOOD LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

She's standing next to a large brown couch, watching a small TV that's constantly emitting a static noise. Playing on it is an older live performance of "HEAD LIKE A HOLE" by NINE INCH NAILS.

She decides to sit down, wiping her tears before watching it. She really gets into it, immersing herself in the music. Everything's fine until her DAD walks by.

DAD
My game's on.

KOTOMI
It's almost over!

DAD
Don't you think they're a little
too loud?

KOTOMI
No... it's the perfect volume. Just
like how I'm gonna be.

There's a pause. The dad looks like he's thinking.

DAD
In another world, maybe.

KOTOMI
Dad!

DAD
You know you'll never be like them.
They have talent.

KOTOMI
Let me show you what I made!

Her dad gives her a mean look before walking away, leaving her alone as the performance on the TV finishes.

We see her face, which paints a face of sadness, with a hint of yearning for something more.

For a moment, we see a younger version of her, with the same expression.

And then, as the setting changes back to her apartment...

INT. TINY APARTMENT - CONTINUOUS

We see her eyes closed, clearly passed out, back out of her dream. She's asleep, although she looks pained.

The alarm on her phone rings, and her eyes spring open.

INT. SMALL BAR - NIGHT

The usual bar is bustling with people, some drunk by the bar counter while mingling about various topics. Live music is being performed in the back on the little platform, and the atmosphere is very lively.

The door swings open, Kotomi walking in with the guitar case strapped on her back. She has a few bandages on her hands, wearing a white shirt with the NINE INCH NAILS logo on it.

Everything seems normal as she heads over to sit at one of the stools. She looks over, seeing Josephine, Zachary, and Felix talking to each other about something.

She waves at them. Josephine glances over, but then doesn't respond, turning back to the other two and continuing to whisper to them.

Kotomi brushes it off, turning back over to the bartender. She almost waves her over, but stops herself once she notices the live music is coming to a close.

She checks her phone, which reads "7:30 PM". There's also a notification from Adeline, which reads "They'll adore it if it's from you! Love u too xoxo, see u tn!".

The bartender looks over at Kotomi, pointing and giving a thumbs up once the person performing before gets off the platform.

Kotomi walks over, passing right by her three friends. She stops for a moment to talk to them

KOTOMI

Hey guys.

JOSEPHINE

... hey.

There's a standoffish feeling in the air, and Kotomi seems confused.

KOTOMI

You feeling better, Josie?

JOSEPHINE

Mhm.

Zachary and Felix are silent. Felix is staring Kotomi down with eyes like piercing needles.

KOTOMI

I'll... be back after. Gotta show what I've been brewing.

She rushes over to the stage, plugging her guitar into the amp and getting on the platform. Nobody seems to initially be paying attention to her.

With her pick ready, she strums a loud chord. Most of the crowd turns their eyes to face her, except for her friends. For those that do look, there's a few dirty looks, and a few suspicious looks.

She ignores them, speaking into the mic.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)

Thank you everyone who came to see me tonight. I know you're all probably expecting one from the usual setlist, but I'm switching things up. How about something by yours truly?

There's a few scattered claps.

Kotomi starts to play, using that chord progression from before and some of the lyrics she wrote down. It's a pretty loud rock tune reminiscent of THE STROKES, but clearly something she made on her own.

It sounds good, it sounds like she has passion in her work. And as she sings, she closes her eyes, completely in the zone. She looks happy; she looks content with this.

When she opens her eyes, still playing, her eyes lock onto Josephine's, who was looking back at her. There's a sinister expression painted on Josephine's face.

Something is wrong in the atmosphere, and as Kotomi continues to stare at her, her music slows down. It seems as if she's focusing on coming to that realization rather than finishing her song.

And then, she stops playing midway through. But still staring at Josephine.

Kotomi opens her mouth to speak, but refrains. She unplugs her guitar, stepping down. There's a few disappointed sighs in the crowd, and a few "awww" and "what?" noises.

When she steps down, she stays in place, looking at her group of friends. She looks away from Josephine to Zachary, who now makes eye contact with her with his good eye.

But quickly, his eye looks away, refusing that eye contact. His expression looks disappointed.

There's a silent exchange they share. It's pretty clear none of them are going to speak yet.

But Kotomi chooses to break the silence.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)
I think it needs a little
improvement, yeah?

FELIX
Oh, for sure. It was a little rough
around the edges.

KOTOMI
Was the chorus too jarring? I tried
to make it surprising.

FELIX
It was definitely out there. But I
think I was a little disappointed.

KOTOMI
Disappointed?

FELIX
It felt like it was building to
something, and then moved to the
next verse.

KOTOMI
I guess it slipped past me?

FELIX
No... it feels intentional. I just
think our brains hear it a little
differently.

JOSEPHINE
Agreed. Differently.

Zachary is still ignoring the conversation. Kotomi casts a final glance at Felix, and then Josephine, before walking past them.

And as she does, she doesn't once look back.

INT. TINY APARTMENT - NIGHT

Now back in her apartment, Kotomi puts her guitar back in its usual spot near her bed. She stretches, extending her arms to the ceiling, and looking up to her light.

It's now flickering, as if the bulb needs to be replaced soon.

She stares at the light, and the flickering seems to sync up with her heartbeat.

And then, she looks at the list on her wall. The flickering stops, and the light is bright as ever.

On the wall, all of the names are crossed out except for "FELIX" and "ZACHARY". For Zachary's name, there's multiple question marks next to it. Next to Felix's name, there's the word "BODYGUARDS" in big, bold letters.

She starts to look around for a marker. She checks the top of her dresser and her bed, with none to be found.

She looks at the floor, scurrying around to find a marker. For some reason, it's nowhere to be found.

She checks near the door, and under the bed. Not a single marker is in sight.

In a moment of defeat, she grabs a SWISS ARMY KNIFE sitting on her dresser, and walks over back to the wall.

She flips it open, the knife extending, shining against the light. Finding a spot next to the other names, she starts to carve an "A" into the wall.

She pauses. And then, she carves a "D". Then, an "E" and an "L".

Her hand is shaking again. But she takes a deep breath and calms down. She looks determined, like she's throwing off baggage weighing down her shoulders.

She carves an "I", and an "N", and finally...

She finishes "ADELINE" by carving an "E". She's now part of the list among the others.

There's a pause, before her eyes dart back over to Felix's name. And then back to Adeline's.

She lets the tip of the knife rest on top of Adeline's name, but then she points it on top of Felix's.

She does this again, and again, a dilemma getting increasingly more difficult.

In a small fit of anger, she drives the knife into the wall, making an indent, before dropping it from her hand. It falls to the floor, clanging against the ground.

Stumbling backwards, she sits down on her bed, staring at the names again. The light starts to flicker again.

Her eyes focus on Felix's name. And she nods her head, the light stabilizing once more.

Pulling out her phone, she quickly flips over to Instagram, tunnel visioned on checking what he's recently posted. She sees the newest post on his account, which she already liked.

It's a picture of Felix smiling and holding a microphone along with other well-dressed rich people. The caption beneath reads:

"CHARITY GALA FOR YOUTH ARTS THIS WEEKEND! WILL BE PERFORMING TO RAISE MONEY, PLEASE COME AND ENJOY! FOOD AND REFRESHMENTS PROVIDED!"

And she bookmarks the post. But right as she clicks the bookmark...

There's a THUD from behind her. She turns her head quickly, looking over towards her window, where a crow is quickly sliding down against the glass. It drops out of sight.

Shaking her head, she turns back, now looking at Adeline's name. Looking at her phone, she opens to the messaging app.

Opening to her messages with Adeline, she starts drafting a message to her. She drafts:

"WE SHOULD GO SOMEWHERE FUN."

But as she's writing it, she notices the most recent message Adeline sent, the one she saw on her notifications when at the bar. She focuses on the "see u tn", and panics. But right when she checks the time...

It's 8:31, and there's a knock on her door.

ADELINE (O.S.)
Sorry if I'm late!

Kotomi looks terrified.

KOTOMI

No, no, you're fine! Just gimme a sec!

She looks around for something to cover the list on her wall. Looking at her posters, she rushes over to grab one with JEFF BUCKLEY on it, ripping it from the wall.

It tears some of the paint off, but she doesn't care. She runs over to the wall that has list, and puts the poster over it. The tape from the poster doesn't stick to the wall, and the poster slides down.

ADELINE (O.S.)

You okay? Did I come at a bad time?

KOTOMI

I'm just changing!

There's a roll of tape on the floor, which she picks up and fumbles between her hands before ripping off a few pieces of tape to put on the poster.

It finally sticks to the wall, although slightly off-centered. There's a little marker sticking out on the left and bottom of the poster, but she dismisses it.

She kicks some of the various things on the floor under the bed, trying to tidy everything up. It's still messy, but she feels content, and looks back up to where the poster she ripped off was.

Underneath was faded black marker, with a set of tally marks.

She pinches the bridge of her nose with her fingers, annoyed.

ADELINE (O.S.)

Kotomi?

KOTOMI

Sorry, sorry, coming!

Running over to the door, she opens it. Adeline stands in the doorway, a guitar case on her back and a small bag in her hand. She is smiling. She pulls Kotomi into a hug.

CUT TO:

EXT. OUTSIDE TINY APARTMENT - CONTINUOUS

A dead crow corpse lies on the sidewalk as a few set of feet walk past it.

CUT TO:

INT. TINY APARTMENT - CONTINUOUS

Kotomi is laying down on the right side of her bed, looking over at Adeline, who's unzipping her own guitar case. Out comes a sleek, white guitar with pink accents that seems to be in very good condition.

From the small bag, Adeline pulls out a laptop, which she sets up against the bed and flips open a software before plugging the guitar into the laptop.

KOTOMI

You came here to serenade me?

ADELINE

I came to see you. The serenading is a bonus.

KOTOMI

Not that I'm complaining. What's it gonna be though?

ADELINE

Oh, you'll see. Just sit, or lay back, and relax.

Kotomi glances over at the messy poster cover up she did, and then back at Adeline. So far, she hasn't noticed it.

Adeline pulls the strap over her body, and then takes a moment to make eye contact with Kotomi

ADELINE (CONT'D)

Still doesn't feel real.

KOTOMI

Be glad it is.

Kotomi smirks, and Adeline lets out a small laugh before she lays her pick against the strings.

And as Kotomi anticipates what will come next, leaning in closer, Adeline starts to play the bridge riff of "BUDDY HOLLY" by WEEZER. The sound is amplified like an electric guitar is supposed to using the laptop.

Kotomi breaks into laughter.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)
Weezer? Really?

ADELINE
You like it?

KOTOMI
I love it. So much charm.

Kotomi coughs after her words, covering her mouth. Adeline looks over nervously.

ADELINE
Caught a cold?

KOTOMI
Just swallowed the air wrong.

ADELINE
Weezer really must've gotten you
all mixed up.

KOTOMI
Oh, you bet.

Adeline plays something else this time - the guitar portion of "RECKONER" by RADIOHEAD. And in the moment, Kotomi seems to calm down.

And everything feels well. The mess of the room might as well not exist, and they might as well simply be two lovers in harmony.

Adeline glances away from Kotomi for a moment, and spots the tally marks on the wall. She slows down her tune to a stop.

ADELINE
Were you counting how many days
we've been together or something?

Kotomi also looks up to the tallies.

KOTOMI
No, no, because I'd eventually run
out of space in my room. It was...
just something stupid from a while
ago.

ADELINE
Oh, tell me then! I wanna know!

She unplugs her guitar, laying it against the bed before hopping in to lay down next to Kotomi.

KOTOMI
Alright, alright...

Kotomi takes a deep breath.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)
I was counting how many of my calls went to voicemail.

ADELINE
That's a silly thing to tally...

KOTOMI
For my parents.

ADELINE
Ah.

Adeline's hand reaches out, resting on top of Kotomi's head. She runs her fingers through her hair.

ADELINE (CONT'D)
Guess we both have shitty parents, yeah?

KOTOMI
Makes it feel a little less shitty.

ADELINE
But hey, we're doing something right for a change. I mean, you have your own place here, even if it needs a little tidying up...

KOTOMI
Hey!

ADELINE
And you're making music! How'd they think about it anyways?

KOTOMI
Could've been better, could've been worse.

ADELINE
See? You just have to put yourself out there a little more. And when the next spot opens up for that agent, you'll already be prepared.

KOTOMI
You're right. And you forgot one
thing.

ADELINE
Yeah?

KOTOMI
I also have you.

Kotomi leans in to kiss her, and Adeline grabs onto her. The two giggle as they exchange a kiss, tumbling over in the bed. They're now on opposite sides.

ADELINE
You're such a flirt, you know that?

KOTOMI
You taught me.

Adeline looks at her with an expression of deep longing, like she had been waiting for someone like this forever. But in the corner of her eye, she notices the poster.

ADELINE
I didn't know you liked Buckley.

KOTOMI
Who doesn't?

ADELINE
Good point.

And she notices the little bit of marker sticking out, just like the tallies on the wall.

ADELINE (CONT'D)
You like writing on these walls,
don't you? Why'd you cover it up
this time?

Kotomi scrambles for an answer, her expression deeply nervous as her cheeks flush red.

KOTOMI
Uh... it's just kinda embarrassing.
Probably better if you don't-

Adeline's already jumping out of bed, careful not to step on anything fragile as she walks over to the poster.

Her hand is about to grab onto it, almost ripping it off.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)

I'm sick!

Adeline stops.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)

I lied to you before. I really am sick.

Adeline turns around, worried. She seems to forget about the poster, now walking back towards the bed.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)

And it's really bad.

Adeline doesn't say anything, climbing back into bed, sitting down this time. She gestures over to Kotomi.

Kotomi takes the hint, scooching over and laying her head down in Adeline's lap. Adeline runs her fingers through her hair again.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)

They gave me medicine, but I don't know if it's helping... I don't know what to do...

ADELINE

It's okay. We'll figure it out.

KOTOMI

There isn't anything to f-figure out. I think I'm gonna...

ADELINE

Shhh...

KOTOMI

I'm gonna die.

ADELINE

No you won't.

For a moment, Kotomi's eyes are filled with guilt. But she closes them, letting Adeline comfort her.

INT. BROOKLYN THRIFT SHOP - DAY

A small, cozy thrift shop houses a frantic Kotomi, who's quick looking through the different sections. Walls littered with snippets from magazines, posters of different clothing brands and musicians. The cashier and other customers linger.

Kotomi runs her fingers past the fabric of various shirts, but shaking her head after none of them seem to quite fit what she's looking for.

She glances around the room before pulls out her phone, which seems to be open to Instagram under an account called "@user300201000", a fresh page with no posts on it.

After going to create a post, she scrolls through her camera roll. It's filled with pictures of her and Adeline, her and her friends, and various picture of scenery. She eventually lands on a video attachment.

On the thumbnail, it seems to be a video of Felix with Josephine. But before she clicks on it...

Someone bumps into her, brushing against her shoulder. She turns around and sees Acacia, who gives her a side eye upon greeting her.

ACACIA

Oh, hey.

Kotomi immediately looks surprised, scrambling to find something to say.

KOTOMI

Hey. Haven't seen you in a while.
Oh, oh, is your shirt okay? I'm
really-

ACACIA

It took me three washes.

KOTOMI

Oh. At least it's out.

There's an awkward pause.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)

So what brings you here?

ACACIA

Trying to find a dress.

KOTOMI

For the gala tonight?

ACACIA

Yeah.

KOTOMI

Me too! Not much around here,
though.

Her enthusiasm is a lot more than her usual attitude.

ACACIA
Eh, yeah. What's-

Acacia looks over towards Kotomi's phone, which is still open to the video. She realizes, fumbling around with as she tries to turn off the page.

Her hands start to shake. And when she tries to flip off of it, she instead simply switches tabs over to a thread on X about the upcoming gala. There's an unfinished reply Kotomi was in the progress of writing where she says:

"Didn't his parents loan everything? Not like he put an ounce of effort into his work, it's all daddy's money."

ACACIA (CONT'D)
Someone's happy to go.

KOTOMI
Oh my- oh my god, I... just-

Hands still shaking, she eventually turns off the phone, slipping it into her pocket. She looks worn out.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)
Just an inside joke between friends.

ACACIA
I hope so.

Acacia walks off, and Kotomi is left eyes wide.

Once Acacia is off to another side of the store, Kotomi strides over to a different part. She finds the section with all the dresses, passing through them fast.

She pulls out a dark purple dress with a discount tag. It's elegant enough for something you'd find at a thrift store, although it's much less grunge than Kotomi's usual.

Glancing back over to the other side, she notices Acacia looking on the wrong side. But as she looks, she sees a shirt peeking out from the selection Acacia is going through.

It's a shirt with a "The Strokes" logo on it, like her usual attire. And for that moment, she's entranced.

But she looks away, walking towards the cashier anyways.

CUT TO:

EXT. OUTSIDE OF THRIFT SHOP - DAY

Holding a bag with the dress peeking out, she lays against the window of the shop, back on her phone again.

Her finger hesitates over the send button of the reply on X.

She sends it.

She then turns over to her photo app, finding the video, and playing it.

Josephine and Felix are arguing playfully in a bar, hands both gripping onto a microphone stand, tugging it back and forth.

Felix starts singing into the microphone, his voice getting louder and quieter as it moves away and towards him.

FELIX (V.O.)

(singing)

Baby when there's tears in your
eyes, you don't have to lie. You
don't need to hide from me, I don't
want to say anything. I see
myself... in you. I see myself-

JOSEPHINE (V.O.)

Wait, stop, stop!

FELIX (V.O.)

What, are my lyrics bad?

JOSEPHINE (V.O.)

They're not YOUR lyrics, dumbass.
Isn't that Geese?

FELIX (V.O.)

No, they're mine! Wrote them
myself.

JOSEPHINE (V.O.)

Don't be an idiot! Anyone in New
York would know that!

FELIX (V.O.)

Might as well be mine now.

When the video finishes, Kotomi edits and lowers the brightness on the video until nothing's visible.

As she goes back to Instagram to post it, she changes the account name to "@realjosephineblackwood", and changes the icon to a picture of Josephine in her camera roll.

Then, she goes to post the video, adding a tag:

"Nepo baby steals lyrics! Fake gala incoming."

As she goes to post it, she lets out a heaving cough, doubling over. Her phone drops out of her hand...

And falls to the floor, the screen cracking.

Regardless, she kneels and hits the post button. She stays there for a moment leaned over, realizing what she's doing.

And then, she stands up taller.

INT. THE GLASSHOUSE - NIGHT

The charity gala is underway in this beautiful venue. Bright chandeliers crowd the ceiling, fancy tables with candles all around the room. It's bustling with many rich-appearing people, servers wearing special HATS, and there's a STAGE setup on one side of the room.

The chatter is loud, and among it all, Felix is smiling and talking with a RICH MAN that seems rather important.

RICH MAN

You're doing wonderful work here.

FELIX

Of course. I'm glad to be giving back to those who need it.

Some pass by, and further in the crowd we see Kotomi, who's wearing the purple dress she bought earlier. She finds a group of CHATTERING PEOPLE (rich), and shimmies her way over.

KOTOMI

Heyyy... y'all are looking great.

CHATTERING PERSON 1

Ah, yes, yes. You are?

CHATTERING PERSON 2

She's probably an investor. You know not to ask those questions.

KOTOMI

Haha, it's fine. I'm just... yeah, an investor. Although, I'm feeling a bit weary...

CHATTERING PERSON 1

About what?

KOTOMI

You see the talk online about where
he gets his money from?

CHATTERING PERSON 1

Vaguely, maybe...

CHATTERING PERSON 2

Oh, oh dear, yes! It is quite
odd...

Kotomi slips past them, waving them off as she looks around
for new people to talk to. Soon, those chattering people went
to talk to another group, distressed looks on their faces.

She finds another group of RICH FOLKS, all who seem to be
discussing something urgent.

RICH FOLK 1

I doubt it's true. AI is everywhere
these days.

RICH FOLK 2

But it sounded just like him...

RICH FOLK 3

AI can't replicate voices like that
yet.

KOTOMI

Oh, it's definitely real. I put it
through a detector.

The others turn to face her, perplexed by her sudden
appearance.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)

He's definitely faking his lyrics.
Bet he's gonna do it again tonight.

RICH FOLK 2

Hm. I'm not donating if he is.

Next, she's walking past a group that seems to be listening
to the clip of the video she posted, with one of the rich
folks from before talking with them. The rumors are
spreading.

After, she looks at another group of people looking at their
phones, muttering about something.

As she peers into the distance, she sees how vast and large
the crowd is. Despite her new attire, everything seems so
above her.

And right when she's turning past another group, heading closer to the refreshments...

She spots Josephine and Zachary talking. She hides behind a nearby group, listening in.

JOSEPHINE

You think he invited her here?

ZACHARY

Yeah, he told me he did. Said it'd look good for his image.

JOSEPHINE

She's gonna pull some shit here, I just know it!

ZACHARY

We aren't even sure...-

JOSEPHINE

It's pretty fucking obvious.

Josephine notices something, looking and almost spotting Kotomi. But when she walks over to the group...

She's gone.

Kotomi is hiding in a nearby hallway, catching her breath.

She looks at the crowd. It's huge, overwhelming, overbearing.

But as everyone suddenly starts shuffling to the tables, taking their seats, she turns her head to the stage where Felix is getting ready to speak.

She has no choice but to scramble back to the crowd before she's seen. She finds a random table with an empty seat, sitting down.

The backs of everyone's heads at the table are turned, so she can't see who they are. Her focus is quickly on Felix.

FELIX

Welcome, welcome everyone. I'm glad you all could make it.

He waves to the crowd, and there's some heavy clapping.

FELIX (CONT'D)

It's an honor to be able to host this Youth Arts Charity Gala, and I'm glad you all came willing to support!

As the clapping comes to a stop, there's a few whispers through the crowd.

FELIX (CONT'D)

To raise money, we'll be doing a set of performances to commemorate the future of arts. In this case, music!

The whispers spread throughout the crowd, and even Kotomi's own table. As one of the people sitting down turns their head, she recognizes it as Daphne, who has a cast on her arm.

Kotomi lowers her head, but doesn't leave the seat just yet.

FELIX (CONT'D)

I'll be opening the performance, and then we'll continue with everyone else. All donations are appreciated and will go to various charities!

A few people seem to be giving Felix odd looks, and his voice grows more nervous.

FELIX (CONT'D)

I can't wait. We'll be starting in... just a moment.

His demeanor is slowly crumbling from the crowd's chatter. And when Kotomi notices that, she takes her chance.

Excusing herself from the table, she keeps her head low as she drifts to the nearest hallway, where she slips into a door labeled "KITCHEN".

INT. GLASSHOUSE KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

Inside is a standard restaurant-style kitchen, with a few WORKERS near the back wearing elegant clothing and preparing desserts.

Kotomi walks over to one side near the dishes, grabbing an empty, dirty tray. She picks it up, before walking near the back where the workers were.

KOTOMI

Such a rush outside. What a day.

WORKER

Right. Trays go over there.

The worker points over to where she took it from, and she nods. But as she steps forward, she bumps into him with her shoulder, the tray falling from her hands.

And it hits him right in the side, which gets him to stumble back and clutch his arm.

His hat falls right to the ground, but he doesn't notice.

KOTOMI

Oh, sorry, I'm so sorry. Long day.

She kneels down, swiping up the hat as she walks past.

WORKER

Hey, you don't have-

Before the worker can realize what's going on, the tray was put back, and Kotomi was gone.

INT. THE GLASSHOUSE - CONTINUOUS

Kotomi is now walking past the tables with the uniform hat on her head.

While Felix waits on the stage, some crew setting up with him, he looks so shaken up that he doesn't look anywhere but at his microphone.

Heading past the stage, she sees a door next to it guarded by a SECURITY GUARD.

SECURITY GUARD

Ma'am?

KOTOMI

Need to do sound check.

SECURITY GUARD

There's already a team on that.

KOTOMI

Yeah, and they're missing me.

The guard thinks for a moment.

SECURITY GUARD

Wait... aren't you that girl that broke the mic stand?

Kotomi looks stunned.

KOTOMI
L-look-alike. That's my sister.

SECURITY GUARD
No, it has to be you! What are you
doing here?

Fear strikes her expression, but she continues awkwardly.

KOTOMI
I-it's a new line of work. Gotta
pay the bills somehow.

SECURITY GUARD
Wow, what a world.

The guard moves aside, and Kotomi runs quickly past him.

INT. GLASSHOUSE BACKSTAGE - CONTINUOUS

It's dark and hard to see, the walls claustrophobic as Kotomi passes as fast as she can through them. There's other security waiting around.

For Kotomi, she feels like the eyes are all on her. When a guard looks towards her, she flinches, before passing by.

Another look causes her to yelp, but then shakes her head and passes by. She coughs into her hand, and then again.

She emerges in a room where the curtains behind Felix show. She's on the other side of the stage, with stairs leading up to it. There's plenty of electronic equipment, and a few people already working on it.

They seem busy, too crowded for her to walk in. One person is looking through audio tracks on a LAPTOP, which is plugged into the other devices. They make a gesture towards another, who says something under their breath to an earpiece.

FELIX (O.S.)
We're about to start!

Kotomi sees the person press a button and walk away.

The speakers blare a low, melodic tune, and Felix starts to sing.

Before she walks over, Kotomi coughs again, a small amount of blood in her palm. She stops, and then...

Kotomi runs with the rest of the group, which are too occupied to notice her on the laptop.

She looks at the upcoming tracks, which are all just labeled "TRACK 1, TRACK 2", and on.

Quickly, she opens the web browser, opening it to Instagram.

She finds the account she made, and the post.

Both tabs are in split screen. She pauses the track 1...

And plays the humiliating audio.

His singing slows, and the crowd starts to make confusing noises.

Kotomi stays there stunned for a moment, before taking a few steps back, dipping around a corner.

She looks down at her hands, shaking again, but she balls them into fists and raises one in front of her triumphantly.

FELIX (O.S.) (CONT'D)
I'm- I'm sorry for the confusion,
there seems to be a technical...
SOMEONE TURN THAT OFF!

As security starts to rush into the backstage area, she stays where she is.

And when they're all focused on the laptop, she starts to slowly creep her way towards the exit.

We see her get closer and closer to the exit.

The light of the venue is visible right in front of her.

She's smiling. It's so close.

But suddenly, her body stiffens up, and she collapses with a loud THUD.

Security turns heads, and some start to crowd around her now seizing body.

Felix walks through the curtains, looking over to see Kotomi.

He plants his head in his hands.

INT. EMERGENCY ROOM - DAY

A spotless, pristine hospital room lies Kotomi, who's groggily waking up. Sitting at the side of her bed is Adeline, with a difficult expression on her face.

KOTOMI

Hi...

ADELINE

Finally, someone's awake.

Kotomi rubs her eyes, before finally concentrating on her.

KOTOMI

I think I ate something bad...

ADELINE

If by that you mean my words, then-

KOTOMI

Huh?

ADELINE

I told you to stay home and get rest...

KOTOMI

It was for Zach... I had to go...

ADELINE

You're too persistent.

There's a slight smile on Adeline's face for a moment, but it quickly gets buried under something more worrisome.

KOTOMI

Well, guess it'll be my time soon...

ADELINE

Why were you backstage?

There's silence in the room for a moment.

KOTOMI

I was? I don't remember-

ADELINE

Come on. Please be honest with me.

KOTOMI

Maybe I forgot because of the, y'know...

Adeline crosses her arms.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)

Okay, I was trying to find Zach...

ADELINE

But he was ON the stage?

KOTOMI

It's just been a long week, Adi.
Everything's been a mess.

ADELINE

I hope that's the only reason why.

Kotomi tilts her head, that comment startling her.

KOTOMI

What's that supposed to mean?

ADELINE

Just... talk. That's all.

KOTOMI

You're not serious.

ADELINE

I just hope you're not the one who-

KOTOMI

I haven't done ANYTHING!

Her voice booms through the room, cutting Adeline off.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)

Sorry, I'm...

ADELINE

You need help, Kotomi.

KOTOMI

I've been taking the-

ADELINE

The doctors know you haven't been.
Don't lie to me, please.

A pause.

ADELINE (CONT'D)

You know I love you.

KOTOMI

I've just been so busy trying to
make most of my time, I forgot.

ADELINE

Well, you're lucky I found out in
time.

KOTOMI

What do you mean?

ADELINE

Last time I was over, when I noticed the pills on your floor, I tried to find the hospital you went to. And when I did, I talked to them about alternatives to your condition. With the right money, of course.

KOTOMI

I can't afford that...

ADELINE

Good thing you're not paying for it alone. There's... a treatment they spoke of that might be helpful.

KOTOMI

You'd really help with that?

ADELINE

Of course I would.

KOTOMI

Alright...

Kotomi's eyes flutter shut, as if she's resting. Adeline smiles and lays back in the seat she was sitting in.

While her eyes are closed, Kotomi hears a voice.

JOSEPHINE

I think we'd be a pretty amazing band.

When Kotomi opens her eyes, in what feels like a dream, she's sitting on a metal chair in a basement studio.

INT. BASEMENT - CONTINUOUS

In the basement, Josephine is holding her bass, Zachary is sitting next to his drums, and Felix is next to a microphone. Kotomi is holding a guitar, and...

Next to her, Adeline has her own guitar.

FELIX

Are we not one already?

ZACHARY

We never... made it official.

The lights are warm, the atmosphere is calm. And Kotomi finally has a smile on her face.

ADELINE

We'll be good as new.

Adeline turns to Kotomi.

ADELINE (CONT'D)

You'll be good as new. You'll be
good as new. You'll be good as-

Kotomi snaps to reality, and she's in a doctor's office, blood being drawn while she sits down in a metal chair.

INT. DOCTOR'S OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

Kotomi is in a daze, looking to watch the blood seep from her veins into the tube connected to her arm. Adeline is standing next to her.

ADELINE

You'll be good as new.

Kotomi nods her head lazily, looking over at the TRIAL DOCTOR next to a computer, typing in medical information.

TRIAL DOCTOR

Assuming everything goes right, and
you follow the regimen, then yeah.
You might be able to hold the
illness under control, at least.

KOTOMI

Yay...

TRIAL DOCTOR

Once we get these blood samples
sent to the lab, we can be certain
on the right treatment. But there
are some general things we can go
over now.

KOTOMI

Uh huh...

TRIAL DOCTOR

Firstly, you'll need to eat
healthy. And take care of your
physical health.

KOTOMI
Microwave...

TRIAL DOCTOR
No microwavable dinners.

A pause, as he looks to the screen, and then back to Kotomi.

TRIAL DOCTOR (CONT'D)
And secondly, you can't over-exert
yourself. Which your friend has
been telling me you've been doing a
lot of.

KOTOMI
Girlfriend...

ADELINE
Take this seriously, please.

TRIAL DOCTOR
Your girlfriend told me you've been
running around everywhere and
playing a lot of... guitar, is it?

KOTOMI
Mhm... the best thing in the world.

TRIAL DOCTOR
No more of that. Too much strain.

Kotomi's ears start to ring, and the light feels a lot
brighter than usual. Despite the lazy nod she gives, the
world might as well be collapsing in on her.

The walls feel closer than they were before.

INT. ADELINE'S APARTMENT - DAY

Things in her apartment seem to be roughly the same as
before. Kotomi and Adeline are sitting together on the couch,
Adeline's arm wrapped tightly against Kotomi, as they watch a
movie.

Kotomi is facing the movie, but then her eyes dart elsewhere.

ADELINE
I wish they'd kiss already.

KOTOMI
Mhm.

ADELINE

Like, they're right there! It's so clear they like each other! And they'd rather walk away!

KOTOMI

It's super annoying.

Adeline looks over, noticing her lack of concentration, pausing the movie.

ADELINE

Kotomi, it's just temporary. You'll be back to playing soon.

KOTOMI

What?

ADELINE

I can tell when you're down.

Adeline flicks her forehead playfully, in which Kotomi groans.

KOTOMI

I'm fine, I promise. I think the stuff they gave me just made me drowsy.

ADELINE

Well, I'm sure it'll wear away soon then.

Kotomi nods.

ADELINE (CONT'D)

Did you tell your parents yet?
About-?

KOTOMI

Ha, not like they'd care anyways.
I'm done trying with them...

ADELINE

Well...

Adeline pauses, and then quickly changes to an even more positive attitude.

ADELINE (CONT'D)

Scratch that, scratch that. I think we need to do something light.
Something fun.

KOTOMI

I could use that right now.

From Kotomi's perspective, everything's a blur. She can barely see Adeline, wiping her eyes to try and focus her vision.

The still image of the television of the two lovers in the movie staring at each other swirls into a cascade of colors.

She wipes her eyes again, and it goes back to normal.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)

Please, anything.

ADELINE

How about...

Adeline stands up, doing a jazz hands motion.

ADELINE (CONT'D)

We go try that new Italian spot that just opened up?

KOTOMI

Ooh... dinner?

ADELINE

Like a little celebration! And it's low-key enough where it doesn't violate the regimen.

KOTOMI

What are we celebrating?

ADELINE

The start of a fresh new life, that's what. Come on, let me choose you something nice to wear, since you have the luxury of being a part of my new show!

KOTOMI

Show?

ADELINE

The Adeline Fashion Show!

She nods along, getting up from the couch, and in a flash...

INT. ITALIAN RESTAURANT - NIGHT

Kotomi is now standing in front of a seat inside a small Italian restaurant, which is filled with dim candle lighting and quiet romantic music in the background.

Kotomi is wearing a dark red top, something smart casual. Adeline is wearing a white dress, sitting down.

Kotomi sits down to join her, looking around at the atmosphere around them.

Adeline giggles, reaching out to grab Kotomi's hand. But still, Kotomi seems like she isn't fully there. And just as the hands come into contact...

INT. ITALIAN RESTAURANT - MOMENTS LATER

Some time seems to have passed, Kotomi trying to listen to Adeline, although the words all sound so distant.

There seems to be bread and butter on the table. She reaches out to grab a piece, and then...

INT. ITALIAN RESTAURANT - MOMENTS LATER

There's now two different pasta dishes in front of them, and the waiter is walking off.

ADELINE

Wow, this smells really good!

Finally, Kotomi can hear her clearly, shaking her head to brush off the state she was in.

KOTOMI

I need to dig in, like right now.

She grabs a fork, taking a bite of some of the pasta. Her face lights up in joy.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)

Best food I've had in forever.

ADELINE

It's amazing, right?

A quiet but noticeable clicking noise starts to play, although there's nothing that seems to be causing it.

KOTOMI
I think I'm feeling a little better
too. Food woke me up.

ADELINE
Usually does that.

A pause. The clicking continues.

ADELINE (CONT'D)
So, as I was saying before, he
finally backed off.

KOTOMI
He...?

ADELINE
My dad! Y'know, how I told him I'd
be moving out and everything?

KOTOMI
Oh, yeah. I'm really proud of you
for that.

ADELINE
Finally I'll get to be myself,
y'know? And of course, with my
wonderful Kotomi at my side.

KOTOMI
You're definitely never getting rid
of me.

ADELINE
That's just how I like it!

The clicking gets just a tiny bit louder, while the two of
them continue to eat.

KOTOMI
Was it really that easy?

ADELINE
Huh?

KOTOMI
Telling your parents off. It's that
simple?

ADELINE
It was the most difficult thing
I've done in my life. But it takes
a weight of your shoulders.

KOTOMI

Uh huh...

ADELINE

I know you said you're done trying
with them... but maybe it might
help you too!

The clicking gets louder.

KOTOMI

Are you serious?

ADELINE

Mhm! I mean, you don't have to,
but...-

KOTOMI

Don't be a fucking idiot, Adi.

Kotomi's eye twitches, the clicking getting louder.

Adeline puts her fork down, and her expression reduces to
something far more serious.

ADELINE

Kotomi.

She doesn't respond.

ADELINE (CONT'D)

What's this all of a sudden?

Kotomi scoffs.

KOTOMI

What do you think?

ADELINE

I'm allowed to talk about your
parents. I wasn't trying to be
rude.

KOTOMI

Yeah, but you surely sounded the
part.

ADELINE

Hey, you know you don't need them.
I'll be there when you perform-

The clicking stops with a SNAP.

KOTOMI
Oh, you bitch.

ADELINE
Kotomi!

KOTOMI
It's so easy for you to say that
when you're actually able to go up
there. Selfish prick.

ADELINE
You don't mean that!

KOTOMI
You don't know what it's-

ADELINE
Does it matter what I know? I see
you, Kotomi.

KOTOMI
You don't.

ADELINE
You think it's easy for me to run
around after you all the time?
Going around screwing everyone
over-

KOTOMI
I'm not-

ADELINE
I wasn't born yesterday.

KOTOMI
You don't understand-

ADELINE
I sure as hell am trying to! But
you don't let me. I'm surprised you
even took the damn treatment!

KOTOMI
I'm not trying to kill myself, why
wouldn't I?

ADELINE
Oh, don't word it like that. Don't-

KOTOMI
I will. What're you gonna do about
it?

ADELINE

You're seriously a piece of work,
you know that?

Kotomi slams the table. Eyes are all on her.

KOTOMI

Then why are you even with me?

ADELINE

Because I want to work with you. I
want to see you happy. I want to-

KOTOMI

Shut up. Shut the fuck up.

ADELINE

I just want to see you smile more,
Kotomi.

Adeline gets up, shaking her head in disappointment. She
pulls out her wallet, taking a wad of cash and putting it on
the table.

ADELINE (CONT'D)

Talk to me when you've calmed down
from... whatever this is.

And Adeline walks away, leaving Kotomi alone in the
restaurant. Even with everyone staring at her, she might as
well be in an empty room. Alone.

EXT. OUTSIDE OF RESTAURANT - NIGHT

Rain pours down on the streets outside on the streets of
Manhattan, right outside the Italian restaurant. Kotomi is
drenched, standing by the door, looking straight ahead.

Besides the bustling cars stuff in traffic from the rain, the
sidewalks are unusually empty.

KOTOMI

Adi...

Her voice is low and hoarse, drowned out by the sounds of the
rain.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)

Adi, I'm sorry...

She starts walking, looking around for Adeline. She's nowhere
to be found.

She increases her speed into a jog.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)
D-don't leave me...

Tears stream down her face, wailing as she's now running.

She gets faster, and faster.

Reaching the end of the sidewalk, she gets lucky by the light on go. She runs across the street.

Puddles splash in her wake, and she's now only looking ahead. With the rain and her tears, it's impossible to see anything.

Her running gets quicker and quicker, until...

She stumbles over, slipping and falling. Catching herself, she's now on her knees, her pants completely soaked from the water on the ground.

She stays there, defeated, in a state way worse than ever seen before. And she's out of energy to even speak.

An OLD MAN is on the other side of the street, and he looks over at her.

OLD MAN
Miss, you alright?

Kotomi doesn't even turn her head, now crying into her palms.

OLD MAN (CONT'D)
Do I need to call someone?

Kotomi's voice is muffled as she responds.

KOTOMI
No, I'm fine...

OLD MAN
If you took somethin' bad, I can get an ambulance.

KOTOMI
Do I look like an addict...

OLD MAN
I don't know...

KOTOMI
JUST FUCK OFF!

The old man looks shocked, shaking his head and walking away.

Kotomi slowly stands up to her feet, her legs shaking while she balances herself.

Without wiping her tears away, she starts running again, although it's much more frantic this time. She's limping, her hair is a mess, her outfit is covered in dirty water.

The sidewalk feels like it goes on forever. No matter how far she runs, it keeps on going, and there's no one else in sight.

Adeline is nowhere to be found, and no other people come to her aid.

With this tunnel vision, she sees nothing but the sidewalk ahead of her, which makes the steady noise of an engine from far away out of place.

The engine gets louder and louder, and her running continues, until..

A SCREECH followed by a HONK blares in her ears, the headlights of a car right in her view as it halts to a stop.

Kotomi stops in her tracks, but the very front of the car bumps into her slightly, and she falls over to her side.

As she's falling, she sees the sidewalk light was on the red stop light.

Her ears ring, her body slow as she pulls herself further out of the street. But she's barely able to move herself.

The DRIVER comes out of the car, running over to Kotomi.

DRIVER

I'm so sorry, I couldn't see you in
the rain!

Kotomi isn't listening. She's simply looking up at the sky, where the clouds and the rain fall.

And hiding within the clouds is the moon. It's brighter than ever.

INT. TINY APARTMENT - NIGHT

Walking out of the bathroom is a disheveled Kotomi, rubbing a towel on her face to dry off. Her hair is still plenty damp, but she's changed into casual clothes.

She immediately throws the towel down next to where her dirty clothes from the date lie. And then, she jumps into the bed, lying down.

As she wipes her forehead, it's clear her hands are shaking again. She looks almost feverish.

She grabs her blanket, trying to pull it over her. Her legs are in the way, and she winces while she moves them out of the way.

Her body moves slow as she aches, eventually giving up and throwing the blanket over to the side.

She lets out a large sigh.

There's a moment of silence, only the buzz of the fan.

She turns her head to the side, the Jeff Buckley poster looking back at her. One of the pieces of tape isn't sticking anymore, exposing some of the wall writing underneath.

She stares at Adeline's name that was carved into it.

KOTOMI

The fuck is wrong with me...

Her whispers barely overpower the sound of the fan.

She turns to look the other way, spotting her guitar in the corner where it always is. It shines extra.

Her hand reaches out towards it, but slams into the bed instead, fingers digging into the mattress.

She grunts in anger.

Her phone, which was sitting on the bedside table, now starts to ring, playing "JIGSAW FALLING INTO PLACE" by RADIOHEAD.

She barely glances over, seeing Adeline's name.

The ringtone keeps playing as she glances back, reaching her hand out to grab the phone.

But her hand only stays in the air, hesitating.

Her breathing grows shallow, her fingers curling ever so slightly as it gets closer to the phone.

The ringtone stops.

She drops her hand, looking up at the ceiling.

Her hand now reaches up towards the ceiling, but the light is too far for her to touch. She lowers her hand.

Slowly, she starts to try and push herself out of bed. Gripping onto the mattress, she tenses in pain while she uses her arms as leverage.

At first, it fails. She falls back onto the bed, sighing.

She tries again. Bracing herself, she pushes herself just barely to her feet.

She almost stumbles immediately, but uses the bed frame to steady herself until she's standing upright.

She walks over to the Jeff Buckley poster...

And she rips it off, exposing all the names. Her eyes drift over to Adeline's again.

Her finger reaches the carving, tracing each letter.

First, she traces the A. Then, the D.

She hesitates, and then traces the E. Then, the L.

Then, the I. The N. And finally, the E.

She stops on that second E, looking at it, her finger not moving one bit.

Her eyes dart over to the table again, and she walks to grab the swiss army knife.

Coming back to the name, she flips open the blade, holding it up to the wall.

The blade presses against the wall, right above the name. She waits, before...

She starts to carve into it.

It seems as if she's slowly making a curve of sorts that tapers at the bottom, and then continues back on the other side.

When it's done, we see it's a shaky heart.

She turns around back to the other side of the room, where the guitar is.

The swiss army knife drops from her hands.

And she walks over towards the guitar.

She picks it up into her hands.

Her lips shake as they curl into a small grin.

And then it grows into a full smile.

INT. SMALL BAR - DAY

The door swings open as a confident Kotomi storms into the bar she frequented before, twirling a guitar pick between her fingers. There's light chatter throughout from other customers.

She slips it into her pocket while she turns over towards the bartender, walking over to sit down at the bar.

When she sits, the bartender looks at her briefly before walking away from her.

KOTOMI

Hey, I want a drink.

BARTENDER

You know you're not welcome here.

Silence. There's a pause while Kotomi angles her head.

KOTOMI

Just get me something cheap.

BARTENDER

I know you ain't an idiot.

Her voice rises.

KOTOMI

Just get me something cheap.

BARTENDER

Not my fault if someone beats your
ass...

The bartender grabs a glass, pouring a beer from the tap and sliding it over to her.

KOTOMI

Think I'll be fine. That'd be a
crime anyways.

BARTENDER

Ya, and so is what you did.

Kotomi takes a sip of her drink.

KOTOMI

Pardon?

BARTENDER

Fucking over everyone so bad that they don't even wanna perform here anymore.

KOTOMI

They must've just grown tired of the shitty people.

BARTENDER

Like yourself.

The bartender scoffs. Kotomi's grip on the glass tightens.

KOTOMI

Shit breaks out every other week, they just wanna play without glass shattering at their feet.

BARTENDER

And they don't want their instruments tampered with either.

KOTOMI

They don't want a server who talks back to them when they ask for a drink.

BARTENDER

You're awfully naïve.

KOTOMI

You don't know a single thing about me.

Kotomi stands up, clutching the glass as she takes another sip. A few glances go her way.

BARTENDER

Enough spreads around here to get an idea.

KOTOMI

You wanna know what else will spread?

A side eye from the bartender. He doesn't answer.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)

When I'm the biggest fucking musician in this city, it'll be all the talk. Biggest musician in the whole world.

BARTENDER

Yeah, sure. And I'll be the best bartender.

KOTOMI

Maybe when you rid that attitude.

BARTENDER

Says yourself.

Kotomi gives a glaring look, before she starts to chug down the drink.

The bartender only watches.

A moment later, he's pulling out his phone.

When Kotomi finishes the drink, she sets it down.

KOTOMI

Are you seriously gonna-

BARTENDER

I said you weren't welcome here.

KOTOMI

I'll slap that phone out of your hand.

BARTENDER

You wouldn't dare.

The bartender steps back, and the phone starts to ring.

Kotomi starts to walk around to the other side of the bar.

A few others look over, some almost standing up to stop her, but they don't do anything.

The bartender backs up further. Kotomi closes in.

KOTOMI

Hang up the phone.

BARTENDER

Or what? You'll break my phone?
Trip me over?

KOTOMI

Oh, shut up. I didn't do any of that.

BARTENDER

Everyone knows.

KOTOMI

And yet I'm still here? Sure it isn't just rumors?

The bartender doesn't answer. Kotomi keeps walking forward as she speaks.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)

Rumors are all you folk can do to put people like me down. People who want to make a difference in their lives, to do something they enjoy. You hate it because you're stuck in this meaningless job, this meaningless cycle. Is it so wrong that I want to break that cycle?

The entire bar is silent. Everyone's eyes are on Kotomi.

And then, the phone...

PHONE (V.O.)

9-1-1, what's your emergency?

Kotomi stops in her tracks. She looks distraught.

BARTENDER

Nothing... thug left already. Sorry.

The phone hangs up. Kotomi doesn't say a thing.

BARTENDER (CONT'D)

I suggest you get lost. Go prepare for your girlfriend's show or something. Be lucky she wasn't here.

KOTOMI

Her show?

BARTENDER

Soon to be.

As if a switch clicks in her head, the gravity of the situation unfolds while she runs away from the bartender, slamming the door open. She's gone.

EXT. ROCKEFELLER CENTER - DAY

Kotomi is running up the sidewalk, turning into the bustling and busy Rockefeller Center. The giant CHRISTMAS TREE stands as the centerpiece, although there are no lights on it yet.

On her phone, she looks at an Instagram post of Adeline posing in front of the tree. She glances around, but with this busy crowd, it's hard to spot anyone specific.

Security and barricades are near the tree, keeping the pedestrian traffic from growing too overwhelming. Kotomi tries to keep her distance from them nonetheless, trailing near the edge of the crowd.

She spots a tuft of pink hair.

She goes to put her phone in her right pocket, and hesitates.

There's something in it already.

She puts it in the left pocket, and starts running towards the hair.

The hair disappears into the crowd. Kotomi doesn't stop, frantically moving throughout.

Pushing past people taking photos and looking at the sights, she keeps going towards the direction where she saw it.

The pink hair appears again. Kotomi runs faster.

And as she speeds up, she closes distance...

The woman with the pink hair looks nothing like Adeline. But she bumps into her anyways.

KOTOMI

Oh, sorry, sorry...

Kotomi shrugs her off, walking past her and looking further into the crowd.

A CAMERAMAN is with a small group, taking pictures of families. He shakes hands when he finishes.

Kotomi notices more pink hair in the crowd. And as she's sprinting through the crowd...

The cameraman spots her.

CAMERAMAN

Hey, you'd look great right there
in front of the tree!

KOTOMI
Not right now.

CAMERAMAN
Come on, I'll give you a discount!

The cameraman's tone becomes more persuasive, and Kotomi has to turn her focus to him.

KOTOMI
You'll kill me.

CAMERAMAN
Don't be rash!

Kotomi holds up a middle finger to him before drifting past, and peering back at the crowd. The pink hair is gone.

KOTOMI
You killed me!

She yells as she gets as far away from him as she can.

And then, when all hope feels lost, she hears that voice amidst a conversation.

YOUNG VOICE (O.S.)
Your hair is so pretty!

ADELINE (O.S.)
Oh, thank you!

Kotomi scrambles to close in on the voice.

She passes by a line to get closer to the tree, and makes it to the other side of the crowd.

Cars and other vehicles pass by on the street at the other side.

And that's when she sees her.

Adeline is nodding and smiling at a child, before turning around to walk towards the sidewalk away from the heart of Rockefeller Center.

Kotomi stops in her tracks. The sun beams down, illuminating Adeline's head as she walks further and further away from her.

In the distance, on the other side of the street, is an UBER.

KOTOMI
(under her breath)
Don't do it, please...

Time feels like it's slowing down. Despite the bustling crowd, the world might as well only be Kotomi and Adeline.

She reaches into her pocket, but then takes her hand out quickly.

Kotomi reaches her arm out, but she's still far from Adeline.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)
(under her breath)
Adi... don't go...

Adeline is now waiting for the crossing light.

Each second feels like an eternity, but Kotomi is stuck where she is.

And then, the light turns white.

As if she was at that crosswalk herself, Kotomi finally begins to run in her direction.

And a swiss army knife falls out of her pocket as she does.

She stops and looks back when it THUDS to the ground, and stares at it.

It's shining back at her.

She shakes her head, turning back and continuing to run.

Adeline starts to cross the street, and even though it's a red light for the cars...

There seems to be a SUPER FAST CAR on the way, being chased by a police car.

It's getting closer, although Adeline doesn't notice.

Kotomi keeps running.

The car gets closer.

Adeline sees the car.

She starts to speed up to make it past before it hits her.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)
ADELINE! I'M SORRY!

Adeline turns around from the voice she instantly recognizes.

Her face is plagued with shock.

The car comes at full force, slamming right into her as she's thrown across the street.

Kotomi only watches as Adeline falls on her back, screaming out in pain.

The car stops for half a second before it swerves and continues past her. A few police cars continue to follow, while one stops by Adeline.

Adeline doesn't move, although her eyes are still open.

They twitch. And slowly move to look over at Kotomi.

Kotomi looks back at her.

The police start to exit the car.

The two continue staring at each other.

Kotomi almost opens her mouth, and then stops.

And then she turns away, disappearing into the crowd.

EXT. OUTSIDE OF OFFICE - DAY

A large building in Manhattan stands tall among the rest, countless windows on each side.

INT. OFFICE - DAY

A small office room sits a large desk that has multiple flyers messily put over to the side, a laptop in the middle, and drawers at the bottom. In the chair sits GERARD FLETCHER (30's, glasses, beard), the booking agent. On the other side sits Kotomi.

Kotomi gives an awkward look while Gerard looks through a few things on his laptop.

GERARD

So, you never signed up.

KOTOMI

No, but-

GERARD

And you're here anyways.

KOTOMI
My girlfriend couldn't make it, so
she told me to just come anyways.

GERARD
And she is...?

KOTOMI
Adeline. Adeline Evergreen.

Gerard scrolls further down on his laptop and sighs.

GERARD
It's you, huh?

KOTOMI
I don't know what you're talking
about. I'm just a capable artist,
and you need someone for this slot,
yes?

A pause. Gerard almost points to the exit, but retreats his
hand.

GERARD
She did miss her appointment...

KOTOMI
I promise I'll be worth it.

GERARD
You're lucky there's no one else.

He scoffs.

GERARD (CONT'D)
How the hell does this even
happen...

KOTOMI
I've been playing guitar for years
and I can sing!

GERARD
So can everyone-

KOTOMI
I've played around like... half the
bars in Midtown and Downtown.

GERARD
Do you get good crowds-

KOTOMI
Most energetic crowds you'll see.

GERARD
You show up on time?

KOTOMI
Always.

GERARD
You're fine with playing on-

KOTOMI
Thursday night, 8 pm, yes. Do you
wanna hear my music? I can play-

He sighs.

GERARD
You can have the gig.

KOTOMI
But-

Kotomi's surprise shows on her face.

GERARD
Like I said, there's nobody else.
Just don't be late, and bring your
own guitar.

KOTOMI
Deal... deal.

Gerard gets out of his chair, while Kotomi remains seated.
She's looking outside the window behind where he sat, spaced
out.

GERARD
Miss, I have places to be. You
can't stay in here.

KOTOMI
Oh, oh, sorry.

She gets up, although her eyes are still stuck on the window.

EXT. OUTSIDE OF BOWERY BALLROOM - NIGHT

Plastered on a wall is a poster labeled "BOWERY BALLROOM
TONIGHT: KOTOMI KUROSAWA, AKA THE 'REDSTAR'".

It flies away into the sky.

INT. BOWERY BALLROOM LOBBY - NIGHT

The lobby of the Bowery Ballroom is bustling with people, many by the bar ordering drinks while some are sitting by the provided couches and chatting away.

"2122" by GEESE is playing on the speakers at a low volume, and it feels like a lively party as everyone waits around.

Among the crowd, there isn't a single recognizable person.

INT. BOWERY BALLROOM BACKSTAGE - NIGHT

Kotomi is standing around backstage, her guitar strapped on as she holds it in her hands. She jumps up and down, hyping herself up.

There's nothing but silence. She peeks through the curtains, and there's nobody. Her face grows panicked.

She looks around for someone to ask about this, but right now nobody else is backstage.

INT. BOWERY BALLROOM LOBBY - NIGHT

The line is now forming, and people are ready to enter the actual concert venue.

Everyone looks excited and curious.

INT. BOWERY BALLROOM BACKSTAGE - NIGHT

Kotomi checks the curtains again. Nobody.

She sees the STAGE MANAGER walking in, and rushes up to her.

KOTOMI
No one showed?

STAGE MANAGER
Doors don't open yet. Be patient.

KOTOMI
Okay. Alright. Just... making sure.

Kotomi nods her head with false confidence.

INT. BOWERY BALLROOM LOBBY - NIGHT

The lobby is now almost empty, with only a few stragglers waiting around. The music is still playing.

INT. BOWERY BALLROOM FLOOR - NIGHT

Many concertgoers are entering the small, compact venue. It's dimly lit, classy, and intimate.

Chatter grows as they stand around, waiting.

INT. BOWERY BALLROOM BACKSTAGE - NIGHT

Kotomi is pacing back and forth, muttering to herself.

STAGE MANAGER

You're ready, right?

KOTOMI

Ready as I could ever be.

STAGE MANAGER

Then get out there. It's two minutes past.

Kotomi hears that, not moving for a second.

And then, she registers the situation, nodding as she pushes herself through the curtains.

INT. BOWERY BALLROOM FLOOR - CONTINUOUS

Kotomi walks onto stage, which has a view of the crowd waiting for her.

She grips her guitar firmly as she steps towards the end of the stage, a sturdy look on her face. Her lips waver.

Everyone's watching her.

She looks out among the crowd, skimming through the heads fast.

She looks for her friends. For Josephine, for Felix, for Zachary. And none of them are there.

She looks for any of the other acquaintances she had from that bar. None of them are here.

And she looks for Adeline. Nowhere to be found.

Despite the mass of people waiting for her to play, she looks awfully lonely on that stage by herself.

She clears her throat.

KOTOMI
It's good to see you all..!

The crowd roars in excitement.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)
I'm sure you've all been waiting...

The crowd gets even louder, everyone anticipating her.

KOTOMI (CONT'D)
For the one and only!

RANDOM FAN
Yeah!!!

She looks over at the RANDOM FAN who yelled above the crowd.

KOTOMI
Get ready for it!

With a guitar pick ready, she gets in the position to play.

She stands there, as if waiting for a cue.

The backing track starts to play. Drums and other background instruments.

There's a pause.

And then another.

The crowd's cheering gets slower, waiting.

The hand holding the pick is firm, like the rest of her body.

And then, there's a beat of sweat dripping down her forehead.

She raises her hand as if to strum a chord, and then...

She stops.

Her knees almost buckle underneath her, her hands letting go of the guitar, which holds on from the strap.

She heaves, and hunches over the stage in clear nausea.

And then, she vomits right towards the stage floor.

The crowd gasps as it all comes out, her hands and legs shaking as she does.

It keeps going.

And when it finishes, she looks down at the mess she made.

And then, she looks at her guitar.

The stage manager rushes out, along with the SOUND ENGINEER, both looking at her in worry.

She doesn't turn back, still staring at her instrument.

She wipes the residue vomit off her mouth.

And she picks up her guitar.

Slowly, she takes the strap off her body, holding the guitar just by the neck now.

She turns around, eyes right at the stage manager...

And she smiles again.

She rushes at her, holding the guitar up like a sword, crashing it down on her head to the beat of the drum.

The stage manager falls to the ground, the cracking of bones heard.

Gasps spread through the crowd.

And then, Kotomi's music starts playing in full swing. It's the same tune as the one she played in the bar.

She goes to the sound engineer next. He tries to run back, but she catches up to him, smacking the guitar against his abdomen to another drum beat. He goes flying to the floor.

She turns over to the crowd, looking at all their scared faces. Some are running to the emergency exits, some are locked in fear.

She runs to the edge of the stage, and...

She jumps down into the crowd, her guitar in hand as she slams it down on the first person she sees.

The people run away from where she is, Kotomi slamming into the ground on beat as she misses the hit. The guitar cracks as it hits the floor, a piece flying off.

She falls to her knees, looking up at everyone and their shocked expressions.

And she's still smiling.

She gets up, and finds the nearest person, using the now-sharp edge of her broken guitar to hit them in the face on beat, blood flying everywhere.

Blood hits her face and the guitar.

She pushes on forward, cutting the next person on beat across the neck. More blood stains her already dyed red hair.

Most of the crowd is dispersed by now, but there's still a few stragglers. She chases them down.

She finds someone who's shaking and cowering, eyes pleading for mercy.

There's one hit to the abdomen to the beat.

And then another.

Blood splatters across Kotomi's shirt, and more on her guitar.

She keeps hacking away to the rhythm of the song.

The body goes limp.

She looks down at the mess she made.

And her smile disappears.

She's alone. And her guitar is now painted an even darker red.

FADE OUT.